

CM flags poor facilities, Delhi to audit all Government schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has decided to conduct structural audits of all Government schools after Chief Minister Rekha Gupta's surprise inspection in North Delhi's Rupnagar, and noticed a lack of facilities there. During her visit, she interacted with students regarding drinking water facilities, fire safety, sanitation, heat-related relief measures and educational arrangements.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has announced a comprehensive structural audit of all Government schools in the capital to assess the actual condition of infrastructure and essential facilities. According to her, the audit will examine the structural strength and safety of school buildings, along with basic

amenities such as drinking water, toilets, cleanliness and fire safety systems.

The Chief Minister visited Government Sarvodaya Vidyalaya in Roop Nagar No 4 early in the morning and carried out a detailed inspection of the campus. She interacted directly with students in classrooms and sought feedback on drinking water facilities, fire safety measures, the condition of toilets, cleanliness, and arrangements to tackle the heat, availability of teachers and the overall academic environment.

During the visit, she also aimed at the previous Government, saying that while its education model was heavily promoted, essential ground-level issues remained unaddressed. There are over 1,200 Government and Government-aided schools

managed directly by the Directorate of Education, GNCT of Delhi.

Students informed the Chief Minister that the school lacked proper access to clean drinking water, with water coolers and RO systems lying non-functional for a long time. As a result, many students were forced to drink tap water directly. They also complained about the poor condition of toilets, saying several doors were broken, regular cleaning was not carried out, and the water supply remained inconsistent.

During the inspection, the chief minister found that the school's fire safety system was also non-functional. Expressing strong displeasure over the lapses, she reprimanded officials and said negligence related to children's safety would not be tolerated under any circum-



stances. She directed the concerned departments to immediately fix all safety-related shortcomings in the school. Students also raised the issue of the shortage of teachers during the interaction.

Calling schools 'temples of education', the Chief

Minister said the Government was committed to ensuring sensitivity, accountability and fulfilment of students' real needs within the education system. She said the structural audit would help assess the actual condition of infrastructure

and essential facilities across all Government schools.

The chief minister said nearly 700 schools in Delhi require new buildings or large-scale redevelopment, as many structures are 40 to 50 years old and have become severely dilapidated.

The audit will cover structural stability, drinking water arrangements, sanitation, hygiene and fire safety preparedness. Directions for the exercise are being issued to the concerned departments.

Questioning the education model of the previous Government, the Chief Minister said the condition of Government schools had exposed the gap between publicity and reality. "Had the previous Government genuinely strengthened the education system, students would not be struggling for basic facilities today," she said, adding that advertisements and publicity alone cannot improve education. "What matters is ensuring real facilities, a safe environment and quality education for children."

The Chief Minister added that over the past year, the Government had been con-

sistently working to strengthen basic facilities and modernise infrastructure in Government schools. The aim, she said, is to provide clean drinking water, hygienic toilets, smart classrooms, digital facilities and safe infrastructure for every student.

Last year, the Delhi Government announced an audit to create detailed digital profiles of more than 1,000 schools and generate real-time insights to identify infrastructure gaps, safety risks and long-term upgrade needs.

According to official documents, the project will digitally map 1,086 Government schools functioning across 799 building premises. Each school will receive a comprehensive digital profile that captures information on infrastructure, available facilities, physical condition, and safety parameters.

Summer vacation for Govt schools to begin on May 11

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi on Friday announced that all Government schools under the Directorate of Education, Delhi, will observe summer vacation from May 11 to June 30, 2026. However, according to the official notification, remedial classes for the students of Classes 9, 10, and 12 will be organised from May 11 to 23, 2026, in schools, depending upon the availability of teachers.

These remedial sessions will aim at reinforcing key concepts and improving overall learning outcomes for the students. The Delhi Government has directed all Government schools in Delhi to organise these classes in the school premises as per their feasibility.

The initiative is aimed at helping students revise key



concepts and prepare better for board-level and critical examinations.

According to the notification, the classes will be held from 7.30 am to 10.30 am, while teachers will report from 7.20 am to 11 am. There will be three periods of one hour each.

In double-shift schools, the classes will be conducted in separate wings.

"For Classes 9 and 10, the focus will be on Science and Mathematics, though heads of school may choose other

subjects based on academic requirements, result analysis and availability of subject teachers," the notification said.

For Class 12, subjects for remedial teaching will be decided by the head of school as per students' requirements.

The DoE has directed school heads to prepare timetables before the vacation and submit them to the concerned Deputy Director of Education (DDE). Schools have also been instructed to

REMEDIAL CLASSES
● Students: 7:30 to 10:30 am
● Teachers: 7:20 to 11:00 am
● 3 one-hour periods daily
● 7:30 am – 8:30 am
● 8:30 am – 9:30 am
● 9:30 am – 10:30 am

cation channels.

Attendance will be marked online, and wearing the school uniform has been made mandatory. Schools have also been asked to obtain parental consent from students attending the sessions.

The circular further stated that teachers have been directed to improve students' performance, while library facilities will remain open for self-study and book issuance.

Heads of schools have been instructed to ensure the availability of clean drinking water and other basic amenities for students attending the classes. Guest

and contract teachers may also be engaged wherever required.

The circular said regular teachers deputed for remedial classes will be granted earned leave, while guest teachers will be paid as per norms.

"DDEs at district and zonal levels to ensure effective implementation of the programme and conduct daily visits to at least two schools where the remedial classes are being held," the circular added.

In double-shift schools, classes will be conducted in separate wings to ensure smooth functioning.

School heads have been instructed to prepare timetables in advance and submit them to the respective District Deputy Director of Education (DDE).

Students and parents must be informed through all available communication channels.

Rapid survey of cooperative societies underway: Officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A rapid survey of functional cooperative societies in Delhi has commenced to assess their contribution to the economy and employment generation, officials said on Friday.

The survey, being undertaken by the Union Ministry of Cooperation across the country, will conclude in September, according to a circular issued by the Registrar Cooperative Societies, Delhi Government.

The survey aims to assess the cooperative sector's contribution to the economy, and includes estimation of Gross Value Added, Gross Value Output, and employment generation by these bodies.

Delhi has around 6,000 cooperative societies related



to agriculture and allied activities, labour, industry, credit, marketing, consumers, security services, motor transport and other areas.

As part of the survey, designated field officers of the National Statistical Office (NSO) may visit selected cooperative societies to collect information about employment, accounts, receipts and expenditure, and other operational

aspects.

They may seek details of payroll registers, muster rolls, books of accounts, profit and loss accounts, balance sheets, and other relevant records.

All cooperative societies and stakeholders should extend support to the visiting NSO officials and ensure the availability of requisite information and records to facilitate smooth and timely completion of the survey, it said.

Treated sewage water planned for construction, parks to save groundwater

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a push for groundwater conservation, the Delhi Government is working on a policy for use of treated sewage water in construction works and irrigation of parks, officials said on Friday.

Water from sewage treatment plants (STPs) operated by the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) and Delhi Development Authority (DDA) is already used extensively for horticulture purposes.

Delhi Public Works and Water Minister Parvash Sahib Singh said a policy is being framed by the DJB for ensuring that large quantity of treated water from STPs could be utilised in activities where use of potable water is unnecessary.

The DJB is actively promoting use of treated effluent and around 89 million gallons per day (MGD) is supplied for non-potable purposes to various agencies such as Central Public Works Department (CPWD), DDA, New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) and Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD).

However, for greater use of treated wastewater, specially in Government construction works and irrigation of parks, the Delhi Government



is now mulling a policy. Other applications, such as its use in firefighting, will also be explored, officials said.

Treated water from STPs is likely to be used first in construction activities undertaken by Government agencies. Later, the possibility of supplying it to private firms at affordable charges, can also be explored, they added.

Technical aspects of using treated water in construction activities will also have to be looked into as the Bureau of Indian Standards has set guidelines in this regard.

Water with pH level between 6 and 8.5, and total dissolved solids (TDS) not exceeding 2,000 parts per million (ppm), is considered

qualitatively good for construction purposes.

Poor quality water can damage iron and concrete and lower construction quality, officials said.

Also, parks maintained by various Government agencies and resident welfare associations (RWAs) can be supplied treated water through pipelines from STPs. Small decentralised STPs could also be set up near parks to treat local domestic sewage water and use it for horticulture purposes, they said.

A 2024 report by the Central Ground Water Board shows that Delhi is extracting more groundwater than it recharges.

Out of the 34 assessed

tehsils in Delhi, 14 have been identified as 'over-exploited', 13 as 'critical', two as 'semi-critical', and only five as 'safe'.

Safe reuse of treated water (SRTW) is emerging as a national priority with pressure rising on freshwater sources due to increase in population.

The SRTW framework is being institutionalised across states and cities for purpose of sustainable development.

Already, Uttarakhand Government has notified its SRTW policy for reuse of treated wastewater. The policy promotes the use of treated water for non-potable purposes such as industrial processes, construction activities, irrigation of parks, green spaces, flushing, sprinkling and other urban uses.

Officials said currently, Delhi's STPs generate about 530 million gallons per day (MGD) of treated water, of which, only around 105 MGD is used, mainly for roadside gardening, green areas, and lake restoration.

The Delhi Jal Board has approved a ₹90-crore project to transport treated water from sewage treatment plants for horticultural purposes across the Capital.

CEO booked over intern's harassment complaint

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has registered a case against the chief executive officer of a private company in South Delhi after a former intern accused him of sexual harassment, intimidation, and abuse of authority during her time with the firm, officials said on Friday.

The FIR was lodged following a complaint filed by the woman, who alleged that she faced repeated misconduct and mental harassment while working as an intern at



the company.

According to police, the complainant accused the CEO of inappropriate behaviour and creating what she

described as a hostile and unsafe work environment during her internship period. She also alleged that she was subjected to intimidation after resisting the conduct.

Police officials said the woman approached authorities after repeated incidents allegedly left her distressed and under pressure. An officer associated with the investigation said a case had been registered and statements of people connected to the matter were being recorded. The police have not disclosed the name of the

accused company executive or the firm involved.

Investigators are currently examining the allegations and verifying the sequence of events mentioned in the complaint. Police said all facts and circumstances related to the accusations are being looked into as part of the inquiry. Officials did not immediately provide details regarding the sections under which the FIR was registered. They also did not specify the duration of the woman's internship or when the alleged incidents took place.

NDMC rolls out monsoon plan with robotic drain survey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has launched its Monsoon Action Plan 2026 with a focus on preventing waterlogging, strengthening emergency response and using advanced technology to monitor underground drainage systems across the Capital's central administrative zone.

NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal on Friday said the civic body had completed 100 per cent desilting work under the first phase before the onset of the monsoon season, while the second phase would be completed by June 15.

One of the key features of this year's plan is the first-ever robotic inspection of underground and covered stormwater drains at Q Point near the Taj Mansingh Hotel. According to NDMC officials, nearly 85 per cent of the survey work has already been completed.

The robotic technology is being used to identify silt deposits, drainage blockages, damaged sections and points where water stagnation is likely to occur. Chahal said desilting through super sucker machines was currently underway at a cost of around Rs 3.5 crore.

He added that next year the robotic desilting and inspection work would be



expanded to cover nearly 3,200 metres in areas including Q Point, DTC Depot and Dayal Singh College. The proposed project is estimated to cost around Rs 43 crore.

Chahal said the monsoon preparedness plan had been designed to ensure uninterrupted civic services and reduce flooding incidents during heavy rainfall. The strategy includes pre-

monsoon preparation, emergency arrangements during rain and restoration work after the season ends.

The NDMC has also started GIS mapping of underground drainage infrastructure, including bell mouths, gully traps, connecting pipelines, manholes and brick barrel drains. Officials said this would help improve monitoring of vulnerable areas and strengthen planning for drainage management.

According to the NDMC, only five major waterlogging-prone locations remain within its jurisdiction. These include Purana Quila, Dayal Singh College area, Panchkuian Road, Hanuman Mandir and Satya Sadan.

MCD plans automatic toll collection at Delhi border entry points

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will soon present a proposal to its Standing Committee to introduce an Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR)-based toll collection system at its border entry points, officials said on Friday.

The Standing Committee will likely address the proposal, implemented in late 2025, in its meeting scheduled for next month, they said.

Officials said the civic body will introduce a multi-

lane free-flow tolling mechanism, similar to national highways, using ANPR cameras and RFID technology to automatically deduct taxes without requiring vehicles to stop at toll plazas.

"We are moving towards an ANPR camera-based toll collection system along the lines of highways. The details are being finalised, and everything is being done as per the direction of the Supreme Court," an official said.

They said the proposed system will use cameras to identify vehicles as they pass through toll points, and RFID tags fitted in vehicles will



work with the cameras for seamless toll tax collection.

Officials said the move will ease long queues and traffic congestion seen at several toll plazas and border entry points in the Capital, particularly during peak hours.

"With the new system, vehicle owners will not be required to stop, and taxes will be deducted automatically, similar to the FASTag system on national high-

ways," an official said.

The development comes after the MCD sent its toll tax department a proposal in October 2025, regarding the hiring of a new agency to operate 156 toll plazas and generate a minimum annual revenue of ₹900 crore.

The department was asked to redraft the proposal in line with court directions, officials said.

Meanwhile, the civic body granted a six-month extension to the existing concessionaire, whose term ended in October 2025, until the new system is finalised and a fresh agency is appointed.

Juvenile held after gun photos on social media; pistol seized

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has apprehended a juvenile after photographs showing him brandishing weapons on social media triggered panic in Northwest Delhi's Mahendra Park area. Police recovered an illegal country-made pistol and two live cartridges from his possession following a late-night operation.

According to Deputy Commissioner of Police, Northwest District,



Akanksha Yadav, the action was initiated after several photographs of a young individual displaying firearms and a knife surfaced on social media platforms. The images quickly drew attention due to con-

cerns over public safety and possible threats to law and order.

Senior officers of Mahendra Park police station assigned a special team from Police Post Badhola to identify and apprehend the suspect. Police said the team launched a focused investigation immediately after the photographs came to notice. Informers were activated, and technical surveillance was initiated to track the suspect's movements.

IN FOCUS



A purple swamphen in a wetland at Pobitora Wildlife Sanctuary ahead of World Migratory Bird Day in Morigaon district, Assam

PTI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Friday directed officials to intensify efforts to provide housing for all, setting a target of building 10 lakh more houses by December 2027.

Addressing the seventh District Collectors' Conference at the Secretariat, the CM said collective housewarming ceremonies under the welfare housing programme should be conducted for 2.5 lakh houses by August 15. "Intensify efforts towards housing for all. By August 15, collective housewarming ceremonies should be conducted for 2.5 lakh houses, followed by another 2.38 lakh houses by December," Naidu said.

According to the CM, nearly two lakh families are expected to require housing sites. He

instructed officials to provide three cents of land in rural areas and two cents in urban areas wherever possible.

He directed authorities to regularise houses constructed on Government land and in hill regions, stating that any policy bottlenecks could be brought before the Cabinet for approval.

Reviewing welfare departments, revenue administration, housing, and summer action plans, the CM instructed officials to ensure housing for all eligible beneficiaries through construction, land allocation, and regularisation measures.

The CM stressed the need to resolve all pending land issues and complete the statewide resurvey process along with the issuance of pattadar passbooks (land documents) by 2027. Likewise, the TDP supremo instructed officials that the



Government must directly improve the quality of life of the poor, middle-class, and vulnerable sections through welfare delivery and social empowerment.

Emphasising social justice and inclusive development, the CM said the State Government would examine extending welfare benefits applicable to the Scheduled Castes to the Budaga Jangam community, pending

approval from the Centre regarding SC inclusion demands. Naidu observed that a special commission has been constituted to study backwardness among BC communities and that appropriate reservations in local bodies would be implemented based on the commission's report.

Further, he instructed officials to focus on livelihood generation through Rural

Auto Nagar clusters across constituencies with significant minority populations, transforming them into livelihood and industrial hubs.

Stressing the need to reduce the financial burden on people, the CM directed officials to work toward lowering expenditure on education, healthcare, and electricity. He said the Government is prioritising welfare and empowerment for weaker sections, ensuring equal opportunities for SC, ST, BC, minority, and economically weaker communities through education, skill development, and employment initiatives.

Highlighting the State's long-term welfare vision, the CM said more than 11 lakh families have already been adopted under the 'poverty eradication' P4 initiative, which combines educational support, economic assis-

tance, employment opportunities, and improved living standards.

Reviewing major welfare schemes, the Chief Minister directed officials to ensure the timely transfer of subsidies under Deepam 2.0, which offers three free cooking gas cylinders per year, on fixed dates.

He noted that ₹3,504 crore has already been spent under the scheme, benefiting 1.08 crore beneficiaries.

Under Stree Shakti, the free bus travel scheme for women, Naidu said over 60 crore free bus journeys have been recorded, with an annual expenditure of ₹1,940 crore.

Likewise, he said the Talliki Vandanam scheme, which offers ₹15,000 per school-going child per annum, is benefiting 67 lakh people, with an allocation of nearly ₹10,000 crore.

Congress, SP will cease to exist after 2027 polls: Keshav Maurya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya on Friday asserted that after the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly Poll, the State will be free of the Congress and Samajwadi Party.

In a post on X in Hindi, Maurya attacked Congress

leader Rahul Gandhi and SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, alleging that during the last general election, the two misled people by claiming the reservation would be abolished.

"The duo of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and SP 'bahadur' Akhilesh Yadav committed the great sin of misleading the public in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections by

falsely claiming the Constitution and reservations would be abolished.

Had this propaganda not been spread, both parties would have barely been able to open their accounts in Uttar Pradesh," he said.

Maurya claimed that now that their "lies" were exposed, "the State will be free of the Congress and SP."

Akal Takht gives 15-day ultimatum to fix anti-sacrilege law

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Amritsar

Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Kuldip Singh Gargaj on Friday gave a 15-day ultimatum to the Punjab Government to remove provisions from the anti-sacrilege law which are "against the Guru Granth Sahib, the Khalsa Panth and the sentiments of the Sikh community".

Speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan on Friday appeared

before the Jathedar here. The Jathedar had asked him to explain why the 'Panth' was not consulted before passing the anti-sacrilege Act.

Notably, the Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Bill, 2026, was unanimously passed by the Punjab Assembly on April 13. It has the provision of stricter punishment, including life imprisonment for any act of sacrilege against the Guru Granth Sahib. After appearing



Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Kuldip Singh Gargaj

before the Jathedar, Speaker Sandhwan did not reveal about the meeting but said, "We are committed to the Panth and will act according to its sentiments. What has been done was as per the sentiments of the Panth."

During the meeting held at the Secretariat of Sri Akal Takht Sahib, both sides held clause-by-clause discussions regarding the law, and the Jathedar sought answers from the Speaker over objections

raised by Sikh institutions, Panthic scholars, legal experts and other Sikh bodies regarding the legislation.

After deliberations, Gargaj told Sandhwan that within 15 days, the Government must remove those provisions from the Act which are against the Guru Granth Sahib, the Khalsa Panth and the sentiments of the Sangat (Sikh community), and which were incorporated into the law without consultation with Sikh institutions.

FROM PAGE - 1

Adhikari takes West Bengal crown

His father, Sisir Adhikari, is a former Union Minister and veteran legislator. Suwendu holds a Master's degree in Arts from Rabindra Bharati University and remains unmarried.

His political journey began in 1995 as a Congress councillor in Kanthi Municipality. In 1998, he and his father joined the newly-formed Trinamool Congress under Mamata Banerjee. Adhikari rose rapidly, winning the Contai South Assembly seat in 2006 and becoming Chairman of Kanthi Municipality. He played a pivotal role in the Singur and Nandigram land agitation (2006-07) that ultimately helped the TMC defeat the Left Front in 2011. Adhikari won the Tamruk Lok Sabha seat in 2009 and 2014 before shifting to Nandigram in 2016. He served as a powerful minister in the Mamata Banerjee cabinet, handling Transport (2016-2020) and Environment (2018-2020) portfolios. Differences with the Banerjee family, particularly nephew Abhishek Banerjee, led to his dramatic exit from the TMC on December 19, 2020, when he joined the BJP in the presence of then BJP president Amit Shah.

In the 2021 Assembly elections, Adhikari defeated Mamata Banerjee in Nandigram by 1,956 votes and became Leader of the Opposition. His organisational skills, aggressive campaigning and deep roots in rural Bengal helped the BJP increase its tally from three seats in 2016 to 77 in 2021, and finally to a historic majority this year. Widely known as the giant killer for twice humbling Mamata Banerjee electorally, Adhikari is credited with breaking the TMC's stranglehold in the coastal districts and consolidating anti-incumbency votes across the state.

As he prepares to take the oath on Saturday, all eyes will be on how the new Chief Minister steers West Bengal towards his promised agenda of development, industrial revival and improved law and order. For millions of Bengalis who voted for change, Suwendu Adhikari's swearing-in will mark the end of one era and the beginning of another.

Amit Shah says West Bengal win will secure...

In a brief reaction, Adhikari, now the CM-designate, thanked Shah, describing him as a "modern-day Chanakya," and vowed to work towards a 'fear-free Bengal' while fulfilling the 'Modi Guarantee' in the state. The oath-taking ceremony is scheduled for Saturday, May 9, at 11 AM, likely at the Brigade Parade Ground in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other senior leaders.

The BJP's decisive win ends 15 years of Trinamool Congress rule and marks the first time the saffron party has formed a government in the eastern state. Shah's address not only celebrated the victory but also set the tone for governance focused on development, security, and cultural aspirations. As Bengal prepares for its first BJP Chief Minister, the spotlight now shifts to the swearing-in and the formation of the new cabinet. Political observers see this as a landmark moment that could reshape the political landscape of eastern India.

Left parties back Vijay, TVK nears power in TN

TVK founder Vijay will have to resign from one of the two constituencies he has won, as per EC norms. Congress party has extended the support of its five MLAs to Vijay, who needs the support of 118 legislators to form Government.

As per the calculations, the strength of TVK and its supporting MLAs now stands at 116, taking into account the requirement of Vijay resigning from one of the two seats he contested from—Perambur in Chennai and Tiruchirappalli East.

That being the case, Vijay now requires two more MLAs' support to usher in his maiden Government and VCK is all set to announce its decision on Saturday, amid indications that it might follow the Left parties. CPI, CPI (M), IUML and VCK have two seats each in the 234-member House.

VCK leader Vanniarasu, a close aid of the party founder, gave clear indication that Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi was keen on getting a share in power, which the TVK is prepared to offer. According to Marxist leader and former CPI (M) state secretary K Balakrishnan, besides the two Left parties, VCK and IUML "have also given letters," indicating they too have extended support to TVK, which originally lacked numbers to form Government. He claimed Vijay is "being invited" by the governor Arlekar to form Government and that he will be sworn-in on Saturday morning.

Welcoming the outgoing Chief Minister M K Stalin's statement urging Governor Arlekar to immediately take necessary steps to ensure that a new Government is formed as per the Constitution, IUML cryptically said its "two MLAs would support the initiatives by the Governor towards the Government formation." The statement by IUML top leader Prof KM Kader Mohideen is seen as a hint that IUML shall in some ways "facilitate" Government formation.

The Left parties, both part of the DMK-led alliance in Tamil Nadu, said that the decision was taken in order to prevent BJP's "backdoor entry" in to the state. They will remain with the DMK vis-a-vis state rights. The Communist parties announced that they will not be a part of the TVK cabinet. Congress with five MLA is also expected to join in Government.

Busted terror network targeted Delhi sites

Some police stations in Uttar Pradesh were also included in the target list, indicating a broader design to strike at soft and strategic targets in the National Capital Region and surrounding areas.

The Delhi Police described the operation as a major success in dismantling a cross-border network that was actively recruiting and radicalising individuals through social media for acts of terror and targeted violence in India. This latest bust comes weeks after the Special Cell arrested two other operatives linked to the same Shahzad Bhatti module in April, highlighting the sustained efforts to neutralise ISI-backed threats.

Officials have emphasised that timely intelligence and swift action under 'Gang Bust Operation 2.0' prevented what could have been a major security incident. Further investigations are underway to trace the full extent of the network, including possible links to other modules and handlers in Pakistan.

Security agencies and state police forces across the country are battling the challenges posed by cross-border terrorism. Constant vigilance is required to safeguard public places, religious sites and strategic installations in the country, a police official said.

China admits backing Pakistan during conflict...

He also described the experience as a demonstration of the close working relationship developed between Chinese technicians and Pakistani forces during the deployment. Another engineer, Xu Da, also confirmed his participation in the support mission, comparing the fighter aircraft to a "child" that engineers had developed and prepared before seeing it tested under combat conditions. Xu said the performance of the J-10CE during the conflict did not come as a surprise to the support teams.

The remarks mark the first official acknowledgment by Chinese personnel that they were direct-

ly involved in technical and operational support activities during the India-Pakistan confrontation over Kashmir last year.

Pakistan remains the only known foreign operator of the Chinese-made J-10CE fighter aircraft, an export version of the J-10C multirole combat jet. The aircraft is equipped with advanced active electronically scanned array (AESA) radar systems and can carry long-range Chinese air-to-air missiles, including the PL-15 missile system.

Islamabad had ordered 36 J-10CE fighter jets and approximately 250 PL-15 missiles from China in 2020 as part of a broader military modernisation programme.

Apart from the J-10CE fleet, the Pakistan Air Force also operates the JF-17 fighter jet, jointly developed by China and Pakistan, as a core component of its combat aviation capability.

The man who made the world fall in love with...

"I think it's very easy for a lot of people to say, He should have done it sooner. Why didn't he act 20 years, 30 years, 40 years ago?" Garrod then asked: "Why didn't we?"

Born in London on May 8, 1926, the same year as the late Queen Elizabeth II, Attenborough was raised on the grounds of what is now the University of Leicester, where his father was a senior leader.

His fascination with nature developed when he was a young boy, riding his bicycle into the surrounding countryside where he collected treasures such as abandoned birds' nests, the shed skin of a snake and, most importantly, fossils.

"I'd find a fossil and show it to my father, and he'd say Good, good, tell me all about it.' So I responded and became my own expert," Attenborough told Smithsonian Magazine in 1981.

He went on to study geology and zoology at the University of Cambridge.

In 1952, Attenborough joined the BBC, working behind the scenes on "everything from ballet to short stories." After he'd been there about two months, the capture of a "living fossil" off the coast of East Africa caused an international stir, and he was asked to produce a short piece about the coelacanth.

That story was told in the studio by Professor Julian Huxley, an evolutionary biologist, who used pickled wildlife specimens and a photograph of a coelacanth to explain the fish's significance. But Attenborough thought television could do more.

"I'd always wanted to do films on animals around the world," he recalled in a 1985 interview with The Associated Press. "But the attitude was, We've got TV cameras in the studio. What's this about spending money abroad?"

In 1954, he finally persuaded the BBC to let him accompany a London Zoo team that travelled to West Africa to collect specimens. That began a decade as host and producer of "Zoo Quest," kick-starting his career in the field.

One of the most famous moments of that long career came during the 1979 series "Life on Earth," when Attenborough encountered a family of mountain gorillas in a forest on the border of Rwanda and what was then Zaire (now Congo).

During that scene, voted one of Britain's top TV moments of all time, a young gorilla lies across his body while several babies try to remove his shoes. Attenborough grins, laughs and is speechless with delight.

"I honestly don't know how long it was," Attenborough later told the BBC. "I suspect it was about 10 minutes, or even a quarter of an hour. I was simply transported."

"Extraordinary, really," he reflected. "It was one of the most privileged moments of my life."

Attenborough has combined his knowledge of television, an understanding of his audience and his commitment to science to create a character who could deliver complicated issues surrounding wildlife, conservation and natural history to a mass audience, said Jean-Baptiste

Gouyon, a professor of science communication at University College London.

"Basically, he gave wildlife television a figure, a front of the house person ... which has come to embody television discourse about nature," Gouyon said. And on this, his centenary, his fans made a point of finding him. In a recorded audio message, he said he thought he would mark the day quietly. As if.

"I've been completely overwhelmed by birthday greetings from preschool groups to care home residents and countless individuals and families of all ages," he said. "I simply can't reply to each of you all separately, but I would like to thank you all most sincerely for your kind messages." And he isn't planning to stop now, Fothergill said.

"He said to me recently he feels unbelievably privileged that a man in his late 90s is still being asked to work. And, you know, he will go on forever. He will die in his safari shorts." (AP)

US, Iran exchange fire in Strait of Hormuz

The US military said none of its ships were hit. Iranian state media said the country's forces exchanged fire with "the enemy" on Qeshm Island in the strait. It also reported loud noises and continuous defensive fire in western Tehran late Thursday.

Iran's Foreign Ministry issued a statement condemning what it called "hostile" US military action against two Iranian oil tankers near the Iranian port of Jask and the strait, as well as strikes on nearby coastal areas.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said his country has been in contact with the US and Iran "day and night" in an effort to extend the ceasefire and reach a peace deal.

Meanwhile, direct talks between Israel and Lebanon were scheduled to resume next week in Washington, according to a US official who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss plans for the closed-door meetings. The official said talks will be held May 14 and 15.

A nominal ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon's Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group has also been repeatedly challenged, including by ongoing fighting in southern Lebanon.

A Chinese-crewed oil tanker was attacked near the strait, in the first such targeting of a vessel affiliated with the country, which has continued to import oil from Iran despite the effective closure of the strait.

China's Foreign Ministry expressed concern, saying the tanker was registered in the Marshall Islands with Chinese crew on board. There were no casualties reported.

On Thursday, Lloyd's List Intelligence, a shipping data company, reported that Iran has created a Government agency to vet and tax vessels seeking passage through the strait.

The Iranian effort to formalise control over the channel raised new concerns about international shipping, with hundreds of commercial vessels bottled up in the Persian Gulf and unable to reach the open sea.

The agency, called the Persian Gulf Strait Authority, is "positioning itself as the only valid authority to grant permission to ships transiting the strait", Lloyd's said.

On Friday, an oil tanker that passed through the Strait of Hormuz in mid-April arrived off South Korea's coast with 1 million barrels of crude. South Korea, which last year imported more than 60 per cent of its crude through the strait, has capped prices of gasoline and other petroleum products. Iran has effectively closed the strait, a vital waterway for the shipment of oil, gas, fertilizer and other petroleum products, while the US is blockading Iranian ports.

Maritime law experts say Iran's demands to vet or tax vessels violate international law. The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea calls for countries to permit peaceful passage through their territorial waters. The US

has threatened to impose sanctions on companies that pay tolls to Iran. The US and its Gulf allies are pushing for the UN Security Council to support a resolution that condemns Iran's chokehold on the strait and threatens sanctions. A prior resolution calling for reopening the strait was vetoed by Iran's allies Russia and China. (AP)

Nida Khan held in TCS case, AIMIM leader...

They succeeded in closing the net on her in a rented flat where she was living with relatives. Her arrest was the culmination of brilliant detection by Nashik Police sleuths. No dramatic chase, just cold technical surveillance: phone pings, bank trails, CCTV, travel patterns and plainclothes spotters who'd been watching the place for days. Forty days of cat-and-mouse ended not with a bang but with the quiet click of handcuffs, said a police official.

This wasn't some low-level clerical issue. Nine FIRs lodged, multiple victims and an organised pattern of targeting young Hindu women at TCS's Nashik BPO unit. Police probe confirmed romantic lures, WhatsApp grooming pipelines, pressure to recite the Kalma, observe Roza, ditch Hindu dress for burqas, eat non-veg and convert outright. One victim was allegedly lined up for a rename to Hania and a one-way ticket to Malaysia. Rape, sexual exploitation, and religious coercion dressed up as office mentorship.

Seven others from the grooming gang are already in judicial custody. Khan was the eighth, repeatedly flagged as the lynchpin by police and prosecutors. Her exact job title became a sideshow: initial reports called her an HR manager; TCS and her family quickly pivoted to telecaller or process associate, no recruitment power, no real authority. Cute spin. Victims and investigators didn't buy it.

They accused her of sitting on repeated harassment complaints, burying inconvenient facts like a married colleague's existing wife and actively coaching women into the conversion pipeline while the gang operated with impunity inside the company's walls. Whether her title was inflated or not, her alleged role was clear: facilitator, enabler, and alleged architect of an operation that treated the workplace as a hunting ground.

After the FIRs dropped in late March, she vanished into thin air with the help of an AIMIM corporator. Cops found she had links to Malaysia and Malegaon; prosecutors used it to torpedo her anticipatory bail. Whether her pregnancy claim was true or not, the judge called the offences serious and ruled that custodial interrogation was necessary. Khan shifted locations and routines. Police had to lean on cyber tracking, informants, and multi-city sweeps. Her husband was questioned earlier. Family insisted she was innocent and pregnant, but police disagreed. The manhunt exposed exactly how far someone entangled in this mess was willing to run rather than face questioning.

TCS, for its part, suspended the accused, shut down on-site operations in Nashik, told staff to work from home, and claimed full cooperation. The SIT has already looped in NIA, ATS, and IB, a clear signal that investigators suspect this wasn't isolated office sleaze but something more structured, possibly with ideological or cross-border threads. Undercover housekeeping staff cracked the pattern; nine women eventually came forward. The corporate gloss couldn't hide the rot.

Khan's arrest closes one chapter but rips open bigger ones. A major Indian IT giant's BPO floor allegedly became a grooming factory. HR systems, the supposed safeguard, either collapsed or colluded. Young women were preyed upon with conversion as both a carrot and a control mechanism.

Suvendu: Architect of BJP's West Bengal win

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Very few in West Bengal were taken aback when, on Friday, Union Home Minister Amit Shah formally anointed one of BJP's most prominent faces, Suvendu Adhikari, as the leader of the party's legislative wing in the State — a decisive move that all but cleared the path for him to be sworn in as the State's ninth and the BJP's first chief minister on Saturday, amid mounting political anticipation and high drama.

In many ways, Adhikari earned the distinction, having dealt two resounding electoral blows to TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee within the span of five years — first in his own backyard of Nandigram during the 2021 Assembly elections, and then, perhaps even more symbolically, in Banerjee's so-called "impregnable"

bastion of Bhabanipur in the recently concluded polls. His victories, coupled with his pivotal role in orchestrating the BJP's watershed triumph in Bengal, firmly cemented his stature as one of the primary architects of the party's remarkable ascent in the State.

Indeed, Adhikari's political journey has been marked as much by confrontation as by calculation, most notably during his five-year tenure as the Leader of the Opposition, when he emerged as the principal challenger to the regime of Mamata Banerjee.

From fierce legislative battles to relentless agitations within the precincts of the Assembly, Adhikari, as the Leader of the Opposition, positioned himself at the forefront of the BJP's campaign against the Government's policies and legislations, often dominating proceedings with combative speeches and



West Bengal chief minister-designate Suvendu Adhikari addresses the gathering after the BJP legislature party meeting in Kolkata, West Bengal

charged interventions on the floor of the House.

That turbulent phase, however, was not without backlashes. In repeated confrontations with the erstwhile TMC establishment, Adhikari, along with several BJP legislators, endured the ignominy of multiple suspensions from the Assembly,

punitive measures that came to symbolise the deepening acrimony between the treasury and opposition benches.

While some suspensions extended through the entirety of an ongoing session of the House, others were equally severe in their own right. One such instance, in

February 2025, saw Adhikari barred from the Assembly for an uninterrupted period of 30 days, underscoring the extraordinary intensity of the political face-offs that came to define that period in the State's legislative history.

Outside the Assembly too, Adhikari remained at the forefront of the BJP's street resistance against the ruling TMC regime in West Bengal.

From spearheading protests over the alleged post-poll violence following the 2021 Assembly elections to leading marches towards State secretariat 'Nabanna' and mobilising cadres over issues of corruption, unemployment and law and order, Adhikari consistently positioned himself at the centre of the party's political offensives.

He played a particularly aggressive role during the agitation surrounding the School Service Commission (SSC) recruitment scam,

repeatedly targeting the Government over allegations of systemic corruption and demanding accountability at the highest levels.

As political tensions deepened across the State, Adhikari emerged as the BJP's principal mobiliser during some of Bengal's most volatile flashpoints.

During the 2023 panchayat elections, he led sustained protests over alleged electoral violence and intimidation, while in 2024, he became one of the most visible faces of the party's agitation over the unrest in Sandeshkhali, accusing the ruling establishment of shielding local strongmen and suppressing dissent.

He also fronted the party's protests in the aftermath of the outrage surrounding RG Kar Medical College and Hospital, seeking to transform public anger into a broader movement against the State Government.

States Focus



NTA ISSUES DRESS CODE ADVISORY FOR CUET-UG 2026

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has issued an advisory for candidates appearing in the Common University Entrance Test (CUET-UG) 2026, informing them about the dress code and permissible items at examination centres. The CUET-UG exam will be held from May 11 to May 31 in India and in 15 cities outside the country.

In an advisory issued on Thursday, the NTA said the examination will be conducted in computer-based test (CBT) mode. It also informed candidates about the dress code and permissible items at the examination centres. According to the advisory, candidates will be allowed to carry transparent water bottles to the examination centres.

Op Sindoor shows India's precise military resolve: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday here said "Operation Sindoor is a testament to the swift, precise, and joint response of the Indian Defence Forces to safeguard national interests," as he called upon the Commanders of the three Services to remain future-ready by learning from the operation as well as the current global security landscape.

Addressing the second edition of the joint Commanders' Conference, he described Operation Sindoor as a short-duration, deep-penetration, high-intensity, and high-impact operation which showcased India's ability to compel its adversary to surrender. The operation was a demonstration of India's growing capabilities

and a symbol of the nation's collective resolve and new military ethos, he added.

Rajnath Singh underscored the need to strengthen capabilities in artificial intelligence, autonomous systems, data analytics and secure communication networks to stay prepared in the rapidly evolving geopolitical security scenario.

He emphasised that future conflicts will increasingly be shaped by hybrid threats, information dominance and operations conducted simultaneously across cyber, space, electromagnetic and cognitive domains.

Highlighting the transformative impact of emerging technologies, he stressed the importance of ensuring integrated national preparedness across all spectrums of conflict.

The defence minister



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh addresses the joint commanders' conference commemorating the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor in Jaipur

appreciated the progress achieved in enhancing jointness, integration and technological adoption across the three Services.

He stated that jointness constitutes a pivotal dimension

within the transformative changes sweeping across the global defence sector. "Future wars will not be won solely through weaponry, but through innovative thinking and enhanced synergy,"

Rajnath Singh said.

He exhorted the Commanders to cultivate the 'element of surprise' to remain unpredictable to the nation's adversaries and secure a strategic edge in any given situation. He, however, urged them to remain vigilant of the element of surprise of the enemy and always stay two steps ahead.

During the conference, the defence minister released a documentary film on Operation Sindoor. The film reaffirms the nation's and defence forces' commitment to operational preparedness and decisive national response capabilities.

He also released the Hindi version of Vision 2047 and the Joint Doctrine for Integrated Communication Architecture, aimed at strengthening doctrinal clarity, interoperability and integrated communica-

tions across the Armed Forces in future multi-domain operations.

The conference, themed 'Military Capability in New Domains', brought together the top leadership of the Ministry of Defence and the Indian Defence Forces to deliberate on emerging security challenges & future readiness.

Comprehensive deliberations were held on future warfare, multi-domain operations, technological transformation and joint capability development. The conference witnessed extensive discussions on cognitive warfare, cyber resilience against evolving quantum and AI-enabled threats, military capability development in emerging domains, indigenous innovation and AI-enabled warfighting concepts.



AMIT SHAH TO REVIEW FLOOD, HEATWAVE READINESS

Union Home Minister Amit Shah will do a comprehensive review of the country's preparedness for dealing with possible floods and heatwave conditions on Sunday. Shah will chair a high-level meeting to assess the readiness of the central agencies, review early warning systems, resource deployment and inter-agency coordination, to ensure zero loss of life and minimal loss to property, according to an official statement.

BJP will have to face public anger for stealing polls: Rahul

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gurugram

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday launched a fierce attack on the BJP, alleging that the party has established a system to "steal" elections, but said their time will come and they will have to face public anger.

He claimed that the BJP stole elections in Haryana, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra and now in Assam and West Bengal.

Gandhi on Friday evening joined the Sadbhav Yatra of Haryana Congress leader Brijendra Singh here and addressed a gathering.

"The BJP stole the elections in Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, and now in Bengal, Assam. They have made a system 'chunav chori karne ka' (to steal the elections). They delete lakhs of names, add lakhs of names, Election Commission is in their control, bureaucracy is in their control, and they think their rule cannot stop now," he claimed.

"But their time is going to come. You will see their time will come. Because people have understood that Narendra Modi ji and Amit



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and Haryana Congress chief Rao Narender Singh with others during 'Sadbhav Yatra', in Gurugram

Shah ji do the work to sell this country - airports, ports, infrastructure, power plants. In the Nicobar Islands, they are selling this thing to Adani ji. People now understand," Gandhi alleged.

"Take it in writing, Narendra Modi tick nahi payenga kyon ki janta mein itna gussa hai (Narendra Modi won't be able to survive, because there is so much anger among the public). No matter how many elections you have to steal, you may do, but you will have to face

the anger which is there in the people. And people decide in India what is going to happen," he said.

The former Congress chief also walked some distance with Brijendra, state party chief Rao Narender Singh and other leaders as part of the yatra before he addressed the public gathering in the presence of Leader of Opposition in Haryana Bhopinder Singh Hooda, and senior Congress leaders Randeep Singh Surjewala and B K Hariprasad.

AAP's clean politics exposed after ED raids in Punjab: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Friday launched a scathing attack on the AAP-led Punjab Government over the recent Enforcement Directorate (ED) raids, alleging that those who once "distributed certificates of honesty" are now facing raids at the premises of their close associates.

The ED on Thursday conducted searches at multiple locations in Punjab and Chandigarh, including the premises of an alleged associate of an Aam Aadmi Party functionary in the State, as part of a money laundering probe against two reality groups on charges of fraudulent



BJP national general secretary Tarun Chugh

change of land use and duping investors, officials said.

BJP national general secretary Tarun Chugh said that the ruling party's claims of clean politics have been exposed, and accused it of patronising corruption and land-related irregularities.

"The reality of the Aam Aadmi Party, which pretends to practise clean politics against corruption in Punjab, is being exposed layer by layer. Those who distributed certificates of honesty are today seeing raids at the premises of their own close associates," Chugh said.

He claimed that the ED, in its official statement, has directly named

a senior AAP leader from Punjab.

"Fake land documents, dubious CLU certificates, encroachment and political protection - this is not merely a builder-related case, but an exposure of land loot under the AAP Government," he alleged.

The BJP leader said that the people of Punjab voted for AAP in the hope of change, but the State is now witnessing deterioration in governance and law and order.

"The people of Punjab gave the Aam Aadmi Party a chance in the name of change. But today, law and order in Punjab has collapsed. Mafias have become stronger, and corruption has become institutionalised," Chugh said.

India successfully tests indigenous glide weapon system TARA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has successfully carried out the maiden flight-trial of an indigenously developed glide weapon system off the coast of Odisha.

The Tactical Advanced Range Augmentation (TARA) system, developed to convert unguided warheads into precision-guided weapons, was tested on Thursday, according to the defence ministry.

"The Defence Research



DRDO conducts the maiden flight-trial of the Tactical Advanced Range Augmentation (TARA) weapon system off the coast of Odisha

and Development Organisation (DRDO) and the Indian Air Force (IAF) successfully conducted the maiden flight-trial of TARA weapon off the coast of Odisha," it said.

It said TARA is India's first indigenous glide weapon system to convert unguided warheads into precision-guided weapons.

The weapon system has been designed and developed by Research Centre Imarat (RCI), Hyderabad, along with other DRDO laboratories to enhance the lethal-

ity and accuracy of a low-cost weapon to neutralise ground-based targets, the ministry said in a statement.

It is the first glide weapon to utilise state-of-the-art low-cost systems, it added.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh has congratulated DRDO, the Indian Air Force and the industry partners involved in the project for the maiden flight-trial of the weapon system.

He described it as a significant development in advancing India's indigenous defence capabilities.

BJP slams Congress as 'historical backstabber' of allies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Friday criticised the Congress, calling it a "dhokhebaz" party and a "historical backstabber", and claiming that no INDIA bloc ally trusted it anymore.

The attack followed a social media post by Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and reports that the DMK sought separate seating for its MPs, away from other INDIA bloc members in the Lok Sabha.

Yadav on Friday posted photographs with outgoing West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee and Tamil Nadu chief minister MK Stalin with the caption in Hindi, "Hum wo nahi jo mushkilon



Shehzad Poonawalla

mein saath chhod dein (We are not the ones who abandon friends in difficult times)".

A letter attributed to DMK MP Kanimozhi Karunanidhi seeking separate seating arrangements for DMK

members in the Lok Sabha in view of the "changed political circumstances" has also surfaced online.

The letter, addressed to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, sought separate seating arrangements for DMK MPs

in the Lok Sabha, stating that the party's alliance with the Congress had "come to an end".

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla claimed the developments reflect growing "distrust" among INDIA bloc allies towards the Congress and a direct attack on its leader Rahul Gandhi.

"Pictures and captions speak a million words. Akhilesh Yadav's latest post is a direct attack on Rahul Gandhi who ditched both Mamata Banerjee and (MK) Stalin and essentially ended the INDIA alliance," Poonawalla said in a social media post. The BJP leader claimed the message from Yadav is that the INDIA

alliance is effectively over.

"Now the message is clear from Akhilesh Yadav ji that the INDIA alliance is over. Congress is having no role in the INDIA alliance and Congress is a deceitful party," he said.

Poonawalla claimed the post came at a time when the "Congress has cheated DMK and gone with TVK in Tamil Nadu and DMK is saying they backstabbed us".

"Mamata Banerjee said Rahul Gandhi backstabbed us with his video in Nicobar. The Congress has only backstabbed its allies — RJD in Bihar, NCP Sharad Pawar and Uddhav Sena in Maharashtra; in Delhi, they have used the Left and thrown them away," he alleged.

Ex-Maharashtra CM writes to RBI about critical currency shortage

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

BJP's Rajya Sabha member and former Maharashtra chief minister Ashok Chavan has written a letter to the RBI, drawing its attention to the "critical currency shortage" in Nanded district, and said the availability of cash was essential for the rural economy.

Chavan has written the letter to the Regional Director of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), Nagpur division, on April 26. "I wish to draw your urgent attention to the critical currency shortage currently prevailing in the Nanded district. We are presently in the peak



Ashok Chavan

of the wedding season, and farmers have also commenced their pre-sowing preparations. Consequently, there is a high demand for cash in the local market," the letter says.

Chavan said that, as per the data from the State Bank of India (Shivajinagar branch),

which serves as the primary currency chest for Nanded district, the "situation is deeply concerning".

While the chest branch limit is ₹450 crore, only ₹70 crore cash was available with it at present, it said.

"Due to this significant gap between demand and supply, banks are forced to impose restrictions on high-value withdrawals. This is directly impacting common citizens, farmers and traders. While banks in rural areas are advising customers to use digital transactions due to the lack of physical cash, the availability of cash remains essential for the rural economy," he said.

States Focus



ONLY TWO THIRD-GENDER CANDIDATES CONTESTED POLLS

Not a single third-gender candidate won a seat in the recently-concluded assembly elections held across five States and a Union Territory, with only two contesting, one each in Kerala and Tamil Nadu, according to Election Commission of India (ECI) data. According to data made public on Friday, both candidates had to forfeit their deposits. A similar trend was seen in the 2021 Kerala and Tamil Nadu Assembly elections. In Kerala, only one third-gender candidate contested the 2021 assembly polls, but had to forfeit their deposit after failing to secure a win. Tamil Nadu saw two third-gender candidates contesting the 2021 Assembly elections, meeting the same fate. Last month, Assembly polls were held in Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and West Bengal, the results of which were declared on May 4.



EX-CALCUTTA HC CJ RESIGNS FROM SIR APPELLATE TRIBUNAL

Former Calcutta High Court Chief Justice TS Sivagnanam on Friday said he has resigned from the tribunal, which was hearing appeals challenging the exclusion of names from the electoral rolls following the SIR exercise. He is one of 19 former judges appointed by the Election Commission of India (ECI) on the direction of the Supreme Court to hear appeals arising from decisions of judicial officers regarding the deletions of names from the electoral rolls. "I submitted my resignation letter to the Hon'ble Chief Justice of Calcutta High Court yesterday," Justice (ret'd) Sivagnanam said.

Pratidin Group faces legal scrutiny over allegedly defaming Assam minister

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Proceedings before the Civil Court at Kamrup (Metro) have placed certain reports, broadcasts and public statements circulated by Asomiya Pratidin, Pratidin Time and associated individuals, including Nitumoni Saikia, under legal scrutiny for allegedly publishing defamatory, misleading and reputation-harming content against Assam Cabinet Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah.

The matter arose following a petition filed before the Court alleging that a series of reports, headlines, interviews and televised statements repeatedly carried unverified allegations and derogatory remarks intended to malign the public image and reputation of the Minister. The petition referred to multiple publications and broadcasts where defamatory expressions, insinuations and politically charged commen-



Outgoing Assam Cabinet Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah

tary were allegedly used against the petitioner. These included articles and headlines published in Asomiya Pratidin and Pratidin Time regarding farm subsidy allegations and matters related to cow purchase for the farm and interviews/comments made by Nitumoni Saikia.

After hearing the matter and examining the records placed before it, the Court observed that a prima facie case had been made out by the petitioner. The Court

Tight security in Kolkata for BJP Govt swearing-in ceremony

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Elaborate security arrangements have been put in place across the city ahead of the swearing-in ceremony of the new Government at Brigade Parade Grounds in Kolkata on Saturday, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and chief ministers of all BJP-ruled States expected to attend the event, police said.

In view of the high-profile gathering, Kolkata Police on Friday issued a notification announcing traffic restrictions on the movement of goods vehicles in parts of the city and its adjoining areas.

According to the advisory, vehicular movement will be regulated on the Esplanade ramp, Khidirpore Road, Hospital Road, Casuarina Avenue and Queens Way



Preparations are underway at the Brigade Parade Ground ahead of the swearing-in ceremony of the new West Bengal government in Kolkata, West Bengal

PTI

starting early Saturday.

A senior police officer said extensive deployment of police personnel, along with multi-layered security arrangements, had been made around Brigade Parade Grounds and key routes leading to the venue. "Special traffic arrangements and diversion plans

have been put in place to ensure smooth movement of VIP convoys and to avoid congestion in central Kolkata.

Commuters are advised to follow the traffic advisories issued by police," the officer said. Police said movement of goods vehicles would remain prohibited in Kolkata from 4

am to 8 pm on Saturday.

However, vehicles carrying essential commodities such as vegetables, medicines, milk and oxygen supplies would be exempted from the restrictions.

Parking restrictions have also been imposed in several areas surrounding the venue.

TMC seeks CBI inquiry into post-poll violence

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Trinamool Congress (TMC) leader Saugata Roy on Friday demanded a court-monitored CBI investigation into the killing of party workers and incidents of vandalism in post-poll violence in West Bengal. Roy said that many party leaders and workers have fallen victim to post-result violence. Asked about the party's loss, he said people may have been angry with the TMC, but the election was not impartial.

Roy condemned the alleged murder of Chandranath Rath in Madhyamgram and claimed that three other TMC workers were killed over the last three days. Rath, a close aide of BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari, was allegedly shot dead on Wednesday night.

"We demand the strongest possible action in the matter, including a court-monitored CBI investigation, so that those responsible are identified and brought to justice without delay," Roy



TMC leader Saugata Roy

said, alleging that the attacks were carried out by "BJP-backed miscreants." He alleged that a large number of incidents involving arson, vandalism and physical attacks on TMC workers and offices had taken place since the declaration of election results on May 4.

Roy cited the killing of TMC worker Biswajit Pattanaik in Belegghata on May 4, alleging that he was attacked in his

house and his body was found outside the residence.

He also referred to the death of Abir Sheikh, a member of a local TMC committee, claiming he was attacked with sharp weapons, allegedly by BJP activists, while returning home on May 5.

The TMC leader alleged vandalism at party offices linked to State minister Arup Biswas in the Vijaygarh-Netaji Nagar area and at the office of councillor Sushant Ghosh near Ruby Crossing.

Claiming that more than 2,000 TMC offices had been vandalised across the State, Roy alleged that party offices in several areas, including Tollygunge, Baruiপুর, Kamarhati, Baranagar, and Howrah, were attacked, while offices in Jagatballavpur and Siliguri were set on fire.

"All this while, Central Armed Forces were looking the other way," he alleged.

Roy also claimed that more than 100 TMC workers in his Baranagar constituency had fled from their homes fearing violence.

Tamil Nadu BJP to stay neutral in Govt formation process

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu BJP on Friday said it "sincerely" respected the will and the mandate of the people and that it would not indulge in any attempts to form the new Government.

The party did not wish to participate in this process and will not vote for any party in the attempt to form the Government, State Chief Nainar Nagenthiran said.

Responding to the

Assembly election verdict four days after the results were announced, he said the BJP, which was committed to the welfare and progress of the people of Tamil Nadu, had participated in the election process with the same fervour.

"However, the election results are gracefully accepted by our party, and we feel that the people of Tamil Nadu have not given any mandate for the BJP to form the Government,"



Nainar Nagenthiran

Nagenthiran said in a statement. The party has won only one seat.

"We sincerely respect the will and the mandate of the people of Tamil Nadu and do not wish to align our party in any attempt to form the new Government in the State of Tamil Nadu. Therefore, we do not wish any active participation in this process and will not vote for any party in the attempt to form the Government," he said.

DMK to wait for TVK's May 10 deadline before next move

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

Senior DMK leader TKS Elangovan on Friday stated that the party would consider alternative political moves only after the deadline set by the Governor for TVK to form the Government expires.

Speaking to reporters, Elangovan noted that the Governor has granted time until May 10 for TVK to prove its ability to form a Government. "We have to wait and see. The Governor has given time until the 10th. Only after that can we think of any other plans," he said,



TKS Elangovan

responding to queries regarding the current political impasse.

When asked about the possibility of the DMK providing outside support to the AIADMK, Elangovan said no such decision has been made. He emphasised that the party is currently observing the efforts being made by other players in the field. On the stance of alliance partners like the VCK and CPI, the DMK leader said he was unaware of their final decision, suggesting that those parties would determine their own course of action.

Congress member's house attacked in Assam's Jorhat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jorhat

A petrol bomb was allegedly thrown at the residence of a Congress worker in Assam's Jorhat district in the early hours of Friday, gutting a portion of the premises where she ran a food joint, police said.

The incident happened around 1.30 am at Rangajan in Titabor police station area. "A probe has begun following a complaint by Rupali Das. More details will be known as the investigation progresses," a police officer said. "The food joint and some spare parts of a vehicle, estimated to be worth around Rs 10,000- Rs 15,000, were gutted, according to the family," he added.

This is the second reported incident of an alleged attack on Opposition members after the Assembly election results were declared on Monday,

in which the BJP-led NDA secured a third consecutive term with a two-thirds majority.

Unidentified persons had allegedly hurled petrol bombs at the house of a Congress candidate in Diphu in Karbi Anglong district late on Monday night, though none of the explosives exploded. In the latest incident, Das said passersby noticed the flames and alerted the family, who were asleep at the time.

"Around 1.30 am, we heard banging on our door and people shouting. We were initially hesitant to open the door, but when we heard the voice of our neighbours, we rushed out," Das said.

Das said her food joint at the front of the premises was completely gutted, with damage also caused to spare parts of a commercial passenger vehicle that her husband operates.

Naidu to launch *Praja Darbar*-style grievance redressal system

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Friday said a dedicated platform similar to 'Prajada Darbar' will be introduced soon to strengthen the public grievance redressal system.

Addressing the seventh district collectors conference at the Secretariat, the chief minister called upon public representatives and officials to work together to resolve grievances. "To strengthen the Public Grievance Redressal System (PGRS), a dedicated platform similar to Prajada Darbar would soon be introduced. Public representatives and officials must jointly work towards resolving grievances," Naidu said.

Drawing inspiration from Singapore's grievance redressal model, he emphasised the need for faster and more localised problem-solving, including at the mandal level.



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu

The CM declared that every Friday would be observed as "Field Grievance Day," during which officials would directly visit constituencies to receive and resolve complaints. Naidu directed collectors to visit each constituency four times every month and treat grievance redressal as a goodwill mission to strengthen people's confidence in the Government.

He also instructed that all video conferences be restricted to a single day to maximise field engagement. Further, Naidu noted that online deliv-

ery of Government services would help reduce corruption, misuse and unnecessary delays. He said nearly 90 per cent of Government services are already available through the WhatsApp governance platform and directed officials to ensure all services are integrated by December.

The CM emphasised the need to improve disaster warning systems, regulate illegal constructions in urban areas and strengthen data-driven governance through integrated dashboards and real-time monitoring systems.

DMK writes to Speaker for change in seating arrangement in Lok Sabha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The DMK on Friday sought a change in seating arrangement for its MPs in the Lok Sabha, saying their alliance with the Congress has ended and it would not be appropriate for its members to sit alongside those of the Congress.

DMK leader Kanimozhi Karunanidhi wrote to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla for changing the seating arrangement in view of the changed political circumstances. "I write to respectfully request suitable changes in the seating arrangement of the Members of Parliament belonging to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) in the Lok Sabha.

"In view of the changed political circumstances and as our alliance with the Indian National Congress has come to an end, it may not be



DMK leader Kanimozhi Karunanidhi

appropriate for our Members to continue occupying the present seating arrangement alongside them in the House," the Toothukkudi MP said in her letter to Birla.

She requested the Speaker to make the necessary arrangements for the members of the DMK parliamentary party to be allotted separate seating, enabling them to effectively discharge their responsibilities in the House.

The Congress, which won

only five seats in the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, has gone ahead in extending support to the TVK in Government formation, thus putting an end to the alliance with its old ally DMK.

The Congress had contested the Assembly polls as part of the pre-poll alliance with the DMK. This has led to acrimony between the two parties, with senior DMK leaders calling this action of the Congress "backstabbing" and "betrayal."

Union Govt launches AI literacy drive to train 10 lakh teachers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Centre has launched a literacy programme aimed at training over 10 lakh teachers in Artificial Intelligence for everyday classroom teaching by 2027. The initiative, "AI Literacy for Teachers", will be implemented by Bodhan AI - a Centre of Excellence in AI for Education incubated at the Indian Institute of Technology Madras. The announcement was made by Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan during the IIT Madras Technology Summit held at Bharat Mandapam on May 5.

The programme seeks to integrate AI into routine teaching practices, including lesson planning, content creation, assessments and student feedback systems, with the aim of reducing teacher workload and improving learning outcomes, according to an official statement.

Pradhan said the initiative would help create a "responsible, ethical and India-centric AI ecosystem in education" aligned with the vision of Viksit Bharat. The senior BJP



leader said, "As we move from vision to execution, initiatives like the AI Literacy Program for Teachers are pivotal to shaping India's unique pathway in artificial intelligence: one that is inclusive in access, interoperable in design, and sovereign in capability." "By integrating AI into everyday classrooms, we are not merely introducing technology; we are empowering our teachers to become architects of a future-ready India. Training 1 million (10 lakh) teachers is more than a milestone of scale; it is the foundation of a responsible, ethical, and India-

centric AI ecosystem in education, firmly aligned with PM Narendra Modi's vision of Viksit Bharat," he added.

Director of IIT Madras V Kamakoti said AI literacy among teachers was essential to ensure meaningful adoption of technology in classrooms.

"India's strength lies in its scale and diversity, and technology must rise to meet that complexity. As AI begins to reshape education, building AI literacy among teachers becomes foundational to ensuring meaningful adoption. "This initiative demonstrates how AI can be inte-

grated into everyday teaching practices, enabling teachers to enhance pedagogy, improve efficiency, and deliver better learning outcomes at scale," Kamakoti said. Bodhan AI Principal Investigator Mitesh Khapra said the programme aimed to make AI a "trusted co-pilot" for teachers by helping them improve instructional quality and save time on routine tasks. The initiative will be rolled out in phases, beginning with pilot projects in the coming months, followed by the launch of the first public cohort on Teachers' Day on September 5. It is expected to scale to 10 lakh teachers by 2027. Aligned with the broader Bharat EduAI stack vision of Bodhan AI, the program focuses on AI-driven lesson planning, automated assessments, multilingual communication tools, administrative workflows and AI-assisted student learning systems, the statement said.

It will be implemented in collaboration with the Union Ministry of Education, school systems such as Kendriya Vidyalayas, Navodaya Vidyalayas and State Governments, among others.

India, Australia review defence ties at 10th policy talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Australia on Friday here reviewed the entire spectrum of their ties and acknowledged the strategic importance of defence industrial collaboration and engagement. These issues were discussed during the 10th edition of Defence Policy Talks, the Defence Ministry said.

The Indian delegation was led by Joint Secretary Amitabh Prasad, while the Australian side was headed by First Assistant Secretary, International Policy Bernard Philip. The discussion reaffirmed the India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.

Both sides welcomed the recent advancements in bilateral defence cooperation. The establishment of the annual India-Australia Defence Ministers' Dialogue in 2025 has enhanced consultation and reflected the growing trust between the two countries. The two sides acknowledged the recent finalisation of key implementing arrangements and continued high momentum of first-time milestones. They looked forward to holding



the first India-Australia Joint Staff Talks later this year.

The co-chairs reviewed the implementation of outcomes from the 2024 India-Australia Annual Leaders' Summit to renew and strengthen the Joint Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation, and develop a Joint Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap.

Both sides welcomed the increased frequency and complexity of joint exercises. They expressed commitment to deepen maritime cooperation and looked forward to continued collaboration between the two countries, enhancing strategic ties & fostering a shared commitment to regional sta-

bility. India and Australia agreed on the next steps to deepen interoperability across all domains. Reaffirming their Defence Ministers' ambitions, they agreed to continue enhancing cooperation with regional partners.

Both nations discussed various training exchanges that have taken place, such as General Bipin Rawat Memorial Young Officers Exchange Programme and the visits between Indian Military Academy and Royal Military College, Duntroon. Such training exchanges build mutual trust, people-to-people connections and sharing of each other's regional and global perspectives.

Temperature to rise further in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast a further rise in temperatures across Gujarat, with several regions likely to experience heatwave conditions over the coming days.

According to weather officials, temperatures in many parts of the State are expected to increase by 2 to 3 degrees Celsius. A yellow alert for intense heat has been issued from May 9 to May 12 in view of the prevailing conditions.

At least eight cities in Gujarat have already recorded temperatures above 40 degrees Celsius. The IMD has warned that heatwave conditions may intensify between May 11 and May 12, particularly in Kutch and Saurashtra.

Heatwave conditions have also been forecast for Ahmedabad between May 11 and May 13.



Somnath gears up for Amrit Parv during PM's visit



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Somnath

Extensive preparations are underway in Somnath ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's proposed visit on May 11 for the 'Somnath Amrit Parv' celebrations, which are expected to draw nearly one lakh people.

A massive dome structure is being erected at Sadbhavana Ground for the main public gathering, while arrangements are also being intensified around the Triveni Sangam area and other key locations in the temple town.

Officials are preparing for a large-scale roadshow, public meeting and cultural programmes as part of the event. Around 1,600 state transport buses are expected to be deployed to facilitate the movement of attendees.

According to preliminary schedules, the Prime Minister may arrive in the morning and leave later in the afternoon after participating in multiple events. Senior State officials and ministers have reviewed preparations at several meetings held in Somnath.

Gujarat Agriculture Minister Jitu Vaghani chaired a review meeting with senior administrative officers to assess arrangements related to security, crowd management, barricading and cultural events. Authorities also discussed plans for special programmes within the Somnath temple precincts, including a Surya Kiran air show and various cultural performances. Officials later visited key venues linked to the Prime Minister's likely itinerary to inspect the ongoing preparations.

Bullet train girder launched in 135 minutes in Vadodara

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vadodara

Construction work on India's first bullet train corridor achieved another milestone after a 40-metre-long heavy girder was successfully launched near the Vadsar Road Over Bridge in Vadodara.

The operation was carried out at one of the city's busiest traffic junctions, making it a technically challenging task for engineers involved in the high-speed rail project. Officials associ-



ated with the project said the work was completed within a short railway block of about 2 hours and 15 minutes through careful planning and coordinated

execution. More than 100 trains reportedly pass beneath the bridge every day, while nearly 70,000 vehicles use the overbridge, adding to the complexity of

the operation. The girder launching process involved the use of advanced engineering techniques and specialised cranes. Authorities said the work was executed without causing major disruption to either railway operations or road traffic.

The successful completion of the launch is being viewed as a significant step forward for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train corridor and highlights the increasing pace of infrastructure development in the Vadodara section of the project.

Aizawl hosts 2nd regional meet on cooperative reforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Cooperation on Friday organised the second regional conference on cooperative reforms in Aizawl, Mizoram.

The conference forms part of a series of regional and national workshops being conducted across the country to strengthen grassroots cooperative institutions and accelerate cooperative-led development. The first regional conference under this initiative was held

earlier in Jaipur.

The conference also marked the first-ever regional cooperative reform conference being organised in Mizoram, reflecting the Ministry's continued efforts to take the cooperative movement to the farthest corners of the country and deepen the reach of cooperative reforms in remote and geographically challenging regions of the North-East.

The Ministry highlighted that cooperative development is now increasingly expanding beyond tradition-



al regions and reaching far-flung rural and border areas, bringing new opportunities for local communities through cooperative-led eco-

nom ic models. The regional conference brought together senior officials from the Ministry of Cooperation, representatives of all North-

Eastern States, including Assam, Arunachal Pradesh, Mizoram, Meghalaya, Manipur, Nagaland, Tripura and Sikkim, along with representatives from NABARD, NCDC, NAFED, NCCF, NDDB, NFDB, NEDFi and various cooperative institutions. Participating states made detailed presentations highlighting the progress achieved in the cooperative sector and the initiatives being undertaken by their respective cooperation departments for strengthening dairy cooperatives, coop-

erative banking, grain storage infrastructure, PACS expansion, fisheries and value-chain development.

States also shared their experiences in promoting exports and market linkages for organic and indigenous products, which remain one of the major strengths and unique opportunities of the North-Eastern region.

The Ministry of Cooperation highlighted that the North-East remains one of the priority regions for cooperative expansion and inclusive economic growth.



Himanta Biswa Sarma reviewing arrangements for the swearing-in ceremony of the NDA Govt in Guwahati on Friday

Banking boom in Bastar: 31 new branches open in remote areas

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

Chhattisgarh's Bastar region, once a hotbed of Maoist violence that also grappled with poor connectivity and lack of basic services, has been witnessing a major transformation as 31 new branches of banks have opened across the division in the last two-and-a-half years, officials said on Friday.

The expansion of banking infrastructure in remote tribal areas that were earlier rendered inaccessible due to insurgency is being seen as a key indicator of growing peace, public trust and development in Bastar, they said.

A new story of transformation is now being written in the Bastar division, and the

most compelling example of this change is that 31 new bank branches have been opened in the region over the past two-and-a-half years, a Government official said.

The banking outreach gained momentum after the formation of the Vishnu Deo Sai Government in December 2023, with financial services now reaching deep interior regions of Bijapur, Sukma, Dantewada, Narayanpur, Kanker, Kondagaon and Bastar districts, all seven districts of Bastar division, he said. New branches were opened in remote locations such as Tarrem, Jagarunda, Chintalnar, Kistaram, Pamed, Samalwar and Kohkameta, areas that were once considered inaccessible due to insurgency, he said.



Chhattisgarh was declared free from armed Maoists on March 31 this year.

Earlier, people had to travel long distances for basic banking work, but now services are becoming available at the village and block levels, he said. The improved banking network has accelerated financial inclusion in the tribal-dominated Bastar

division, enabling people to more easily access bank accounts, digital payments, crop loans, insurance, pensions and self-employment schemes, he said. Benefits of various Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) schemes, such as the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, PM-Kisan Samman Nidhi, tendu leaf bonus payments, Van Dhan

Yojana and social security pensions, have now been reaching beneficiaries directly into their bank accounts, reducing the role of middlemen and increasing transparency, the official added.

Women self-help groups have also benefited significantly from easier access to banking and credit facilities, which has boosted livelihood activities and small enterprises in rural areas, he said. It has also strengthened the local economy by improving access to financial assistance for farmers, traders and youth. Digital transactions through UPI, mobile banking, micro-ATMs and Aadhaar-enabled payment systems have been increasing rapidly in villages, he said.

SC asks West Bengal Governor to appoint VCs to 3 universities

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday asked the West Bengal governor, RN Ravi, to appoint vice chancellors to three State universities from the names shortlisted by a search-cum-selection committee headed by former CJI UU Lalit.

With the top court's order, the festering dispute between the governor, who is also the chancellor, and former chief minister Mamata Banerjee over the appointment of VCs in 36 state-aided



universities came to an end. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalaya Bagchi expressed satisfaction over the development and recorded its appreciation for the efforts put in

by former CJI Lalit, Attorney General R Venkataramani, appearing for the office of the governor, and senior advocate Jaideep Gupta, who represented the State Government, in the resolution of VCs in the three remaining universities - North Bengal University, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad University of Technology and Netaji Subhash Open University -

within four weeks.

The bench then disposed of the plea filed by the West Bengal Government in 2023.

The dispute was going on between the governor and Banerjee over the appointment of VCs in 36 state-aided universities.

In a bid to end the tussle between the two top constitutional functionaries in the State, the top court had on July 8, 2024, constituted the search-cum-selection committee headed by former CJI Lalit to oversee the appointments. It had sought a

response from the governor's office on the plea alleging inaction in giving assent to the West Bengal Universities (Amendment) Bill 2022, which was passed by the State legislature in June 2022.

The West Bengal Assembly had in 2022 passed a bill to replace the governor with the chief minister as the chancellor of all the state-run universities. The court had then issued a notice to the principal secretary to the governor and the Centre seeking their replies.

No maintenance if wife leaves husband without valid reason: HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Gujarat High Court has upheld a Family Court ruling denying maintenance to a woman who chose to live separately from her husband without sufficient justification.

Justice Hasmukh D Suthar dismissed the woman's revision plea and observed that under Section 125(4) of the Code of Criminal Procedure, a wife is not entitled to maintenance if she refuses to reside with her husband without reasonable cause.

The case arose from a maintenance application filed by the woman after her 2009 marriage. She had alleged harassment and cruelty by



Gujarat High Court

her husband and in-laws, claiming she was forced to leave her matrimonial home. However, the Rajkot Family Court rejected her plea in 2013, prompting her to challenge the order before the High Court.

During the proceedings, court noted contradictions in the petitioner's testimony. In cross-examination, she reportedly admitted that her original application did not clearly state that she had been deserted or expelled.



Editor's
TAKE

Lessons in resolve, readiness and restraint

The anniversary of Operation Sindoor serves as a reminder that it requires preparedness, political clarity, technological advancement and public unity

It is one year since India launched Operation Sindoor on May 7, 2025, in retaliation for the terrorist attack in Pahalgam, where 26 innocent people were massacred, creating outrage across the country. The nation, in one voice, demanded action to show resolve and teach the perpetrators a lesson so that they would not dare commit such a heinous crime in the future. The action was swift and precise, and the result was astonishing. It decimated nine terror camps belonging to Jaish-e-Mohammed and Lashkar-e-Taiba, whose outfits had executed the terrorist act. One year on, India continues to reflect on a military operation that was a turning point in the country's security doctrine and strategic posturing – the resolve of a New India, which will not tolerate terrorism and will go all out to protect and secure its people.

The operation was conducted between May 7 and 10, 2025, by the Army, Navy, Air Force and the Border Security Force along the western frontier, targeting terrorist infrastructure and military facilities in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's message on the anniversary was important as it reflected how Operation Sindoor has come to represent national resolve, military preparedness and coordinated statecraft. The foremost takeaway was coordination and seamless jointness among India's armed forces. It also instilled a sense of relief that the country was no longer going to tolerate such acts and had the mettle to retaliate rather than plead for relief. India's response was calibrated, targeted and time-bound, aimed at neutralising threats without triggering uncontrolled escalation.

What was a major military success was ably backed by diplomacy, as India was able to convince the world that it had retaliated militarily only to destroy terror camps without causing harm to civilians in Pakistan. In this respect, Operation Sindoor reflected India's evolving diplomatic maturity. The operation also highlighted the significance of self-reliance in defence production. Indigenous technologies, surveillance systems and defence platforms reportedly played a critical role during the operation. In recent years, India's push for Atmanirbhar Bharat in defence manufacturing has often been viewed through an economic lens. Operation Sindoor demonstrated that self-reliance is equally a strategic necessity.

At the diplomatic level, the operation underlined the importance of narrative management and international outreach. India successfully portrayed the operation as a counter-terror measure rather than an act of aggression, thereby maintaining its diplomatic credibility.

However, Operation Sindoor also offers sobering lessons. Military success cannot become a substitute for long-term political and diplomatic engagement. While deterrence is essential, sustainable peace requires addressing the issues of extremism, cross-border terrorism and regional instability diplomatically. The operation reaffirmed that India possesses both the capability and the will to defend its interests decisively. But its deeper lesson lies in balancing strength with restraint – a hallmark of a responsible and confident power.

Historic mandate for change in Bengal

The mandate reflects growing aspirations for development, governance reforms, cultural confidence and institutional accountability, while also marking the rise of the BJP as the principal political force in Bengal



ASEERVATHAM
ACHARY

The victory of the Bharatiya Janata Party in West Bengal marks one of the most defining moments in contemporary Indian politics. More than merely an electoral triumph, it signifies a major political and social transformation in a state that has historically been shaped by ideological loyalty, regional dominance, and deeply entrenched political traditions. The verdict reflects a decisive shift in public consciousness, driven by aspirations for development, accountability, security, and governance aligned with broader national priorities. For millions of voters across Bengal, the election became not simply a battle between two political parties but a referendum on the future direction of the state.

The scale of the BJP's victory itself underlines its historic significance. In the 294-member Assembly, the party secured 207 seats, comfortably crossing the majority mark and establishing a commanding two-thirds majority. The All India Trinamool Congress (AITC), which had once dominated the state with 215 seats, was reduced to just 80. This dramatic reversal reflects not only growing dissatisfaction with the incumbent regime but also a powerful endorsement of an alternative political vision centred on governance, stability, and development.

What makes the mandate even more remarkable is the sheer scale of the BJP's expansion. The party retained all 77 seats it had won in the 2021 Assembly elections and succeeded in flipping an extraordinary 129 constituencies from the Trinamool Congress. Such a massive electoral swing is rare in Indian politics and points toward a broad realignment of voter sentiment cutting across regions, communities, and social categories.

A large share of these gains came from South Bengal, traditionally considered a Trinamool Congress stronghold. Of the 129 flipped seats, 77 were concentrated in districts such as North 24 Parganas, Hooghly, Paschim Medinipur, South 24 Parganas, Purba Medinipur, Howrah, Kolkata, and Jhargram. North 24 Parganas alone accounted for 18 flipped seats, followed by Purba Bardhaman with 14 and Hooghly with 12. Districts that had previously delivered near-total victories to the AITC witnessed a dramatic political turnaround, indicating that the change was structural rather than temporary.

The BJP's rise in West Bengal was neither sudden nor accidental. It was built over years of organizational expansion, ideological persistence, and sustained grassroots mobilization. Thousands of karyakartas worked under difficult circumstances, often facing intimidation, political hostility, and violence. Many party workers lost their lives while defending democratic participa-



THE ELECTION RESULTS REFLECT A PROFOUND TRANSFORMATION IN BENGAL'S POLITICAL IMAGINATION. THE BJP'S VICTORY IS NOT MERELY AN ELECTORAL MILESTONE BUT EVIDENCE OF ITS EXPANDING GRASSROOTS ACCEPTANCE ACROSS BOTH URBAN AND RURAL BENGAL

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tion and political pluralism. For the BJP and its supporters, therefore, the victory is not merely electoral but deeply emotional, symbolising years of sacrifice, resilience, and unwavering commitment.

The ideological roots of this transformation are also linked to the legacy of Syama Prasad Mookerjee, one of Bengal's most prominent nationalist leaders and the founder of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh. His vision of national unity, cultural confidence, and political integrity continues to resonate strongly within the BJP's political narrative in Bengal. The party successfully connected this historical legacy with present-day aspirations for economic development, governance reforms, and institutional accountability.

The election took place against a backdrop of growing dissatisfaction with the Mamata Banerjee-led government. Allegations of corruption, political violence, intimidation, and administrative bias increasingly dominated public discourse. Reports of post-poll violence, booth capturing, and suppression of opposition workers raised concerns about the health of democratic institutions in the state. At the same time, issues such as illegal infiltration and demographic imbalance became politically significant, particularly in border districts. For many voters, the election became an opportunity to express frustration over governance failures and demand greater stability, security, and fairness in administration.

Another major dimension of the election was the perception among sections of society that cultural and religious expressions were being selectively restricted. Controversies relating to Durga Puja processions, Ram Navami celebrations, and administrative permissions created resentment among many voters, especially within the Hindu community. These concerns were viewed not merely as religious matters but as issues connected to cultural rights and civil liberties. The BJP effectively channelled this sentiment by presenting itself as a defender of Bengal's cultural identity, traditions, and civil-

sational heritage. At the centre of the BJP's campaign stood Prime Minister Narendra Modi, whose leadership played a decisive role in shaping the electoral narrative. Modi's emphasis on development, welfare delivery, national security, and inclusive governance resonated across social groups, particularly among women, youth, and first-time voters. Throughout the campaign, he consistently projected the vision of a "double-engine government," arguing that alignment between the Centre and the state would ensure faster development, smoother implementation of welfare schemes, and more effective governance.

Modi's political instincts became evident during the campaign itself. He repeatedly suggested that the Trinamool Congress would struggle in districts where it had once enjoyed overwhelming dominance. The final results validated much of that assessment.

Equally significant was the organisational strategy crafted by Union Home Minister Amit Shah. Known for his meticulous electoral planning and booth-level management, Shah played a central role in converting public sentiment into electoral success.

The BJP's performance in constituencies with substantial Muslim populations further demonstrated the effectiveness of this strategy. Despite assumptions that such areas would remain politically inaccessible, the party secured important gains, indicating that governance and development narratives were capable of cutting across traditional political boundaries.

The election also highlighted the growing importance of issue-based politics in Bengal. The BJP concentrated its campaign on themes such as infiltration, corruption, governance deficits, economic development, women's safety, and employment generation. This contrasted with the Trinamool Congress's reliance on emotional slogans and personality-driven politics. As a result, the slogan "Khela Hobe" gradually gave way to "Vikas Hobe," symbolising a broader shift in voter priorities toward governance and development.

Overall, the election results reflect a profound transformation in Bengal's political imagination. The BJP's victory is not merely an electoral milestone but evidence of its expanding grassroots acceptance across both urban and rural Bengal. It signifies the emergence of a new political discourse centred on governance, development, cultural identity, and institutional accountability.

For West Bengal, this mandate opens the possibility of a new political era. The challenge before the BJP now lies in translating electoral success into administrative delivery while balancing Bengal's rich cultural heritage with the aspirations of a modern and economically dynamic society. If the expectations of the electorate are fulfilled, this victory may ultimately be remembered not merely as a change in government, but as the beginning of a larger political and developmental transformation in the state.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Why India must revive social forestry for energy security



BIJU
DHARAMAPALAN

2ND OPINION

The recent disruptions in LPG supply across several parts of India have exposed an uncomfortable reality: the country's everyday energy security rests on a fragile and highly centralised system. Small hotels, roadside eateries and households alike struggled as cooking gas became irregular or unavailable.

In this context, the idea of social forestry deserves renewed attention. Introduced in India during the 1970s and 1980s, social forestry was never just about planting trees. It was a broader vision of community self-reliance, encouraging villages and local institutions to grow fuelwood, fodder and timber on common lands, roadsides, canal banks and private fields. At its core was a simple but powerful principle: essential resources, especially cooking fuel, should remain locally available and sustainable.

Over the years, however, the rapid spread of LPG connections under welfare schemes significantly changed India's energy habits. LPG improved millions of lives by reducing indoor pollution and relieving women of the burden of collecting firewood. Yet it also created near-total dependence on a centralised fossil-fuel-based system.

At the same time, India is gradually losing traditional ecological knowledge. Younger generations, particularly in urban and semi-urban areas, are increasingly unfamiliar with managing biomass resources such as twigs, crop residues and fuelwood. This is not to glorify old smoky chulhas, which were often harmful in poorly ventilated homes, but traditional knowledge of sustainable biomass use formed an important part of India's rural resilience. Losing that knowledge entirely leaves communities with fewer alternatives during emergencies.

Ironically, India already possesses strong policy frameworks for afforestation and green development. Programmes such as the Green India Mission, the National Afforestation Programme, CAMPA funding and the Nagar Van Yojana have invested heavily in restoring degraded landscapes and expanding tree cover. Yet these initiatives are largely viewed through the lens of environmental conservation and carbon capture, rather than as part of a decentralised energy strategy. That gap needs to be bridged.

Reviving social forestry today does not mean returning to the past. It means combining traditional wisdom with modern planning and science. Panchayats could develop dedicated energy plantations with fast-growing species such as bamboo, subabul and regionally suitable native trees. Farmers could plant fuelwood species along field boundaries without affecting crop production. Schools, colleges and urban communities could participate in creating green belts that serve both ecological and practical purposes. True self-reliance is not limited to industry or technology. It begins with basic necessities such as food and fuel. India's agricultural economy already produces enormous quantities of biomass, which, if managed properly alongside social forestry, can supplement modern fuels like LPG. The objective is not to replace LPG, but to ensure that communities are never left helpless when centralised supply systems fail.

Ultimately, reviving social forestry requires a cultural shift. Trees must be seen not merely as decorative elements or environmental symbols, but as living assets connected to livelihoods, energy security and sustainability. Replacing ornamental exotic plants with useful native species can strengthen both ecology and local resilience.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is the Dean of Academic Affairs at Garden City University

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

When folklore meets marine science

The enduring mystery surrounding the so-called "Cadborosaurus" once again demonstrates humanity's fascination with the unknown depths of oceans and rivers. The strange creature discovered in 1937 near Haida Gwaii, with its unusual appearance resembling a mythical sea serpent, naturally inspired legends and speculation. Yet modern scientific interpretation suggesting it was merely a decomposed basking shark reminds us how nature can sometimes create illusions more powerful than fiction itself. What makes such mysteries compelling is the way folklore and science continuously interact.

Rare sightings of marine species often fuel public imagination, especially in regions where traditional storytelling remains deeply rooted. India too possesses similar tales from the Sundarbans and riverine regions of eastern India, where unidentified aquatic creatures were once believed to be supernatural beings before later explanations linked them to crocodiles, dolphins or decomposed marine animals. These stories reveal not ignorance, but humanity's instinctive curiosity toward unexplored natural worlds. Oceans still remain among the least understood frontiers on Earth. Rather than dismissing such legends entirely, they should inspire greater marine research and environmental awareness.

RAJINDER NARULA | PATIALA

Tagore's vision is timeless

Rabindranath Tagore's birth anniversary is not merely a cultural observance but an occasion to revisit the timeless relevance of one of humanity's greatest literary and philosophical minds. Emerging from the intellectual vibrancy of Bengal Renaissance-era Jorasanko, Tagore transformed literature into a bridge between nature, spirituality and human consciousness. His poetry and songs continue to resonate because they transcend geographical and political boundaries. In works like Gitanjali, Tagore blended lyrical beauty with profound philosophical depth, enabling Indian thought to reach global audiences.

His Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913 was not simply a personal honour; it marked the arrival of Indian literature onto the world stage. Yet Tagore's greatness extended far beyond literature. His educational vision at Visva-Bharati University promoted freedom of thought, creativity and harmony with nature. Tagore preserved a universal humanism that rejected narrow nationalism and divisive identities. Today, in an increasingly fragmented world marked by intolerance and conflict, Tagore's immortal appeal for a world "without fear" remains deeply relevant. His writings continue to remind humanity that true civilisation rests not on power, but on compassion, creativity and freedom of spirit.

VIJAY SINGH ADHIKARI | NAINITAL

Constitutional consistency matters

India's constitutional history clearly demonstrates that Governors have often invited the single largest party to form governments even in the absence of an absolute majority, leaving the ultimate test of legitimacy to the Assembly floor.

Karnataka in 2018, Maharashtra in 2019, and Goa and Manipur in 2017 all witnessed controversial yet constitutionally defended gubernatorial decisions based on this principle. Against such precedents, any deviation in similar situations naturally attracts public scrutiny.

If certain decisions are justified elsewhere as constitutional convention, selective interpretations in other states inevitably create perceptions of political bias. The essence of parliamentary democracy lies in allowing elected representatives to determine majority support transparently through a floor test. Raj Bhavan cannot become a substitute for legislative judgment.

Governors, as constitutional heads, are expected to act as neutral facilitators rather than appear aligned with political preferences. Frequent controversies surrounding gubernatorial discretion risk weakening public trust in federal institutions. In politically sensitive situations, transparency and consistency are therefore essential to preserve democratic credibility.

R NARAYANAN | MUMBAI

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BORDER SECURITY FAILURE IN MANIPUR RAISES ALARM

The shocking militant attack on villages in Manipur's Kamjong district near the India-Myanmar border exposes the fragile security situation prevailing in the sensitive northeastern region.

The torching of houses in Namlee, Wanglee and Choro villages by heavily armed militants has not only displaced innocent villagers but also created deep fear among border communities already living under uncertainty. What is most disturbing is the reported ability of nearly 100 armed militants to cross the international border undetected.

Such a serious breach naturally raises questions regarding intelligence coordination, border surveillance and operational preparedness in a strategically vulnerable area. Border residents cannot be left to fend for

themselves while armed groups move freely across difficult terrain. The immediate deployment of Manipur Police commandos is necessary, but long-term measures are equally important. Strengthening border fencing, improving intelligence-sharing mechanisms and enhancing cooperation with Myanmar authorities are essential to prevent recurrence of such attacks. The safety of civilians must remain the foremost priority.

The incident also highlights the humanitarian dimension of the conflict, as terrified villagers were forced to flee into forests in the dead of night to save their lives. Lasting peace in Manipur can only emerge through stronger security, political dialogue and restoration of public confidence.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Mamata: Rise, rebellion and the reckoning of Bengal’s stormy petrel

Defeated by the very saffron force she once allied with, Mamata now faces the most searching moment of her career — one marked by questions over strategy, opposition unity, political miscalculations and the changing mood of Bengal. Her fall is a larger commentary on the volatile nature of power and personality-driven politics



ANIL ANAND

The “stormy petrel of Indian politics”! She truly fits the bill of this adage. A fighter to the core who refused to accept the “injustice” done to her by her parent party, the Congress. She walked out to set up a political party of her own, squarely based on her street-fighting skills and enormous capacity to lead

from the front. Rising from scratch after remaining a Union Minister and president of the West Bengal Youth Congress, Mamata Banerjee, a maverick to the core, was and is a rule unto herself who never accepts any hegemony but has a strong tendency to dominate. The white cotton-saree-clad, simpleton-looking diminutive woman briskly walking in her trademark white hawai chappals led the newly founded Trinamool Congress to new heights before the fall with a thud.

Who could have even dreamt of plotting the downfall of the Left citadel anchored by the indomitable comrade Jyoti Basu, who remained Chief Minister of West Bengal for a record period? There was none to challenge it, with Congress having fallen by the wayside after being further weakened with the quitting of Banerjee and her supporters.

She did literally achieve what was perceived to be an impossible task. The Left’s fortress had fallen and Banerjee rose like a colossus and dominated West Bengal politics for over a decade till the debacle of the 2026 Assembly election came.

Keeping aside the controversies surrounding the poll process for the time being, she was beaten at her own game — defeating the Left — by the new emerging power in the state, the Bharatiya Janata Party. The latter fully trudged on the communal contours, rising on the controversial bogey of Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voter lists by the Election Commission of India. Ordered in a huff, which resulted in the deletion of lakhs of voters within no time, it put a question mark on the entire process.

The once stormy petrel of yore was defanged by none other than a political party, BJP, with which she had once been in alliance and became the Railway Minister in the Atal Bihari Vajpayee dispensation. There is no doubt that her aligning with the saffron party at that juncture opened a window for the BJP in West Bengal for the first time, despite the founder of the party’s former formation, Bharatiya Jana Sangh, Shyama Prasad Mukherjee, being a native of the state.

Was it Banerjee’s miscalculation to have sided with the BJP squarely out of her hatred for the Congress on the lines of the socialist brigade led by former Defence Minister George Fernandes?

The cases, though, are not comparable. Strong dislike for Congress was a common thread. After all, both of them, born mavericks, were Cabinet colleagues in the Vajpayee government. Both of them overshot their respective ideologies based on secularism to make a common cause with the “Hindutva agenda” to checkmate the Congress and at the same time keep politically afloat.

While Fernandes had somewhere meekly surrendered, as during the twilight of his political career the once firebrand leader had lost his sting before the towering Vajpayee-Advani duo, Banerjee stood her ground and refused to budge before the same BJP, now helmed by yet another duo from the same formation, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah.

So far so good. All this while, till she lost the election and the Chief Minister’s chair, Banerjee abhorred the rickety INDIA bloc of the opposition parties, at times ridiculing it, particularly Rahul Gandhi. Not only did she play hide and seek at crucial junctures, but at times her tantrums weakened the opposition unity even before it could take shape.

Was it to still indirectly help her erstwhile ally-turned-enemy who has ultimately consumed her? Or was it to force her fellow opposition party leaders to accept her supremacy and leadership unconditionally?

She might not have liked to help BJP (read Modi-



Shah), but her unpredictability and her mercurial ways of functioning did aid the saffron party by jeopardising, knowingly or unknowingly, the cause of opposition unity. In the end, it added to Modi’s strength.

Well, true to her nature, she suddenly discovered her long-lost love for the INDIA bloc minutes after her defeat. A sullen and crestfallen Banerjee, in her first press conference after a massive BJP “wave”, talked of her next goal to strengthen the alliance. “Not as a leader but as a commoner (read worker)” was the catchphrase of her presentation.

Except for Gandhi (read Congress), most of the opposition leaders and their outfits seem to have ignored the “might” of Modi despite the BJP failing to muster a simple majority on its own in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. The three glaring examples are those of Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray, Nationalist Congress Party supremo Sharad Pawar —both the parties are now split and the leaders nursing their wounds — and now Mamata Banerjee lording over the defeat of Trinamool Congress. But for marginal splits in her ranks, here and there, she withstood the Modi-Shah combine’s onslaught at engineering a major split, as has happened in the other two parties.

Who can forget the unceremonious transition of Nitish Kumar from Bihar’s Chief Minister, vacating the chair for BJP, to Rajya Sabha MP? And Biju Janata Dal chief Naveen Patnaik is licking his wounds after being waylaid by an “old and trusted ally”, the BJP.

However, the duo seemed to have other plans up their sleeves, which an overconfident and arrogant Banerjee either ignored to see through or inimitably decided to take head-on. Was she ignorant about the ground realities and changing electoral map and people’s mindset? Did she fail to counter the polarising agenda of the BJP and fall into their trap by trying to match it with a similar counter, though of a different shade?

These and many more questions will haunt her in the time to come. What baffles one the most is why she did not plan to unitedly enter the poll arena to face BJP’s growing influence, armed with statecraft.

It is ironic for the opposition unity that most of its leaders remember INDIA only either after electoral defeat or during times of crisis. A sturdy framework for opposition unity has to be cemented during normal times, with the leaders keeping their egos and hypothetical ambitions aside.

No one is sure as to how Banerjee’s defeat in her native state will strengthen the INDIA bloc. She has weakened her case to spearhead the combine en route to becoming a prime ministerial candidate. Instead, leaders such as her and DMK chief M K Stalin, both of whom lost their Assembly seats, should restart the effort at opposition unity on a very humble note.

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SINCE 1865

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‘Super monday’: Boredom as ballot, spectacle as sovereignty



ACHARYA PRASHANT

On the fourth of May, three sitting Chief Ministers lost power and a film star became the likely next chief minister of Tamil Nadu. The vocabulary that surrounded these results was, as always, ceremonial: “mandate,” “popular verdict,” “historic upheaval,” words that imply an electorate exercising considered judgment. That courtesy is not incidental to electoral democracy; it is load-bearing. Without it, the ceremony would be required to account for itself more honestly.

Mamata Banerjee, who had governed West Bengal for fifteen years, lost her own seat at Bhavanipur as her party was routed by the BJP. MK Stalin lost his own Kolathur seat to a TVK debutant. In Kerala, the CPM yielded after a decade of consolidated dominance. And in Tamil Nadu, the man

who will in all likelihood be the next chief minister is Vijay, a film star whose manifesto is considerably newer than some of his blockbuster. The analysts called it a historic upheaval. The vocabulary worked overtime.

What actually happened is considerably simpler, and considerably less flattering to the idea of the voter as a sovereign exercising considered judgment: the voter got bored. This is not anti-incumbency, and the distinction is not academic. Anti-incumbency implies a specific form of disappointment, a government that made promises, fell short, and was held to account by an electorate that was paying attention. What the results reveal is something far more ordinary and far more intractable. The ego, the actual unit of electoral action beneath all the aggregated data, has a structural relationship with its objects: it seeks them, uses them, grows accustomed to them, grows tired of them, and moves toward the next available option. Not because the object failed to deliver, but because the ego’s restlessness is not produced by the object at all. The source of the restlessness is the ego itself, a fact it will not examine, and so it keeps changing what surrounds it in place of changing what it is.

Consider what the DMK-AIADMK history in Tamil Nadu reveals. For close to fifty years, the Tamil electorate sorted itself between two parties sharing a genealogy, a vocabulary of symbols, and a shared claim to represent something deeper than mere preference for a face. If that commitment had been real, the abandonment could not have happened at the speed and scale at which it happened. What dissolved was not commitment but attachment, and attachment has shallow roots, which is precisely why it can be uprooted so quickly when someone arrives with a more luminous image. Vijay’s ascent does not represent a rejection of Dravidian politics; it represents the unmasking of what Dravidian politics always was for most of its voters: an attachment to a style of performance. When the performance grew familiar and another, more spectacular, became available, the audience drifted. Nothing in this deserves the name of democratic awakening.

The most instructive Indian example is not from Super Monday but from nearly half a century ago. The 1977 general election, fought in the immediate aftermath of the Emergency, produced what appeared to be the most morally charged verdict in independent India’s history. A population that had suffered suspension of civil liberties, forced sterilisations, and press censorship voted the Congress out. Within three years, the Janata coalition had collapsed. And in 1980, the same electorate returned Indira Gandhi to power with a large majority. The voter who had risen in passionate defence of democracy voted back the person who had suspended it, within a single electoral cycle. If anti-incumbency were a real phenomenon, this reversal would be inexplicable. As an expression of the ego’s boredom cycle, it requires no explanation.

What the actor-politician reveals is not an aberration but a confession, and the South deserves credit for the candour its critics mistake for political naivety. Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh have a long history of electing professional actors to their highest offices: MGR, NTR, and now, in all probability, Vijay. When a state elects a film star as its chief minister, it is not making an error in judgment; it is acknowledging, without the decorum that dresses the same reality up elsewhere, that the electorate has always been choosing between images. The professional actor has trained for precisely what electoral competition demands: the projection of an image that an audience will find compelling, and the calibration of emotion for people who did not gather to be informed but to be moved. The North’s politicians are also actors, the rally, the roadshow, the calculated display of righteous anger, the tears that arrive on cue, but they do not describe themselves in those terms, and the voter colludes in not naming what is clearly visible. The South has, in this specific sense, arrived at a more transparent arrangement.

The voter who surveys the Super Monday results and asks what went wrong with Mamata’s Bengal or Stalin’s Tamil Nadu will find abundant material: misgovernance, administrative complacency, accumulated resentment. All of it is available, but none of it reaches the root. The fifteen years of Trinamool rule were chosen, ratified, and extended by the same people who have now chosen something else. If the government was what it was, it is in significant part because the electorate was what it was, and the electorate is not substantially different now: only restless in a new direction, bored of the last face, freshly attached to the current one.

But a consolation is also, by definition, a substitute: what one performs instead of the thing one cannot bring oneself to do. Toppling a chief minister is what the voter does in place of examining himself. It is the change that keeps the real change at bay, the noise that fills the silence in which an inconvenient question might have become audible. There is, beneath all the noise of Super Monday, only one question worth asking, and it will not be put to air on any channel: if the voter has changed his government for the seventh or the tenth or the fifteenth time, and if the problems said to have motivated each successive verdict, dignity, employment, security, fairness, ordinary safety, continue in their essential form despite every renewal and every fresh mandate, at what point does the continuous ceremony of changing governments begin to look less like the exercise of popular sovereignty and more like the elaborate, inexhaustible activity of a self that has decided, with extraordinary thoroughness, never to examine what has not changed?



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ISHAAN SAXENA

why we have been unable to eradicate poverty despite an abundance of resources. Selfish behaviour will invariably lead to a sub-optimal outcome, which is why it is unrealistic to glorify the utopian idea of equality. The contours of the political landscape have decisively altered, and the decline of the Communist Left Front was inevitable.

To illuminate this peculiar truth and an unconventional view, one must understand the Prisoner’s Dilemma and its application in the real world. Here is the central dilemma. Imagine you have been apprehended for a crime along with another individual. You are put in separate cells, and each of you has been accused of the crime. Now, if you defect and snitch on the other prisoner while they keep quiet, you receive a short sentence - let’s say two months - and they get incarcerated for eight years. If you both defect and rat each other out, you both receive a sentence lasting four years. If you both refuse to speak to the authorities, you both receive one year in

prison for obstructing justice. The most rational thing to do is to keep quiet, but you also do not want the maximum sentence, so you snitch. The other individual does the same, and both of you get locked up for four years. Now, this may seem like a theoretical dilemma, but its application in international relations is wide-ranging.

Prisoner’s dilemma payoff structure

Charles Kindleberger, an eminent economic historian, postulated the Hegemonic Stability Theory. Quite simply, it says that a vital prerequisite for stability in the international financial and trade regimes is a hegemon (superpower) that induces stability and balance in a world fraught with national self-interest. It guides the tenor of international relations. Without the existence of a hegemon, the world would plunge into a rudderless era fraught with diverging concerns and inherent conflict. Think about it. The existence of a hegemon diminishes the chances of a Prisoner’s Dilemma. When we had a bi-polar world, the world was engulfed in a crisis: the Cold War. Now, one could argue that the Cold War was a battle of ideology, but even if the two superpowers had similar resources, cooperation would have been an impossibility. How would the contours of international relations change if each state decided to cooperate? Why do states not collaborate effectively when it is in their best interest to do so? This leads to a security dilemma and contributes to a profound disconnect in aligning international foreign policies. It is indeed a tragedy of rational behaviour. States will always



prioritise themselves over collective security. And because states prioritise their own security, this leads to a very costly outcome. Some states will always be endowed with more resources, and equality is an impossibility.

That is why communism is a distant dream. When Karl Marx posited his theory of Dialectical Materialism and the establishment of a communist society, it was a theoretical perspective. It incorporated Hegel’s dialectical method, which focused on change through inherent contradictions, with a philosophy focusing on materialism (matter). The central idea he spearheaded was that through contradictions in society, class differences would

emerge and the capitalist model would make room for communism. But communism requires collective cooperation, yet individual self-interest will lead to collective failure. Again, it is the Prisoner’s Dilemma. Even a contentious and widely debated topic like eradicating poverty is misguided. Everyone can clearly visualise the collective benefit of lower poverty rates. It mitigates the extent of crime and stimulates productivity, thereby benefiting the economy. But this requires spending money, and governments do not cooperate, again hoping others would bear the cost. We are again left with a sub-optimal scenario. Lamentably, this is a vicious cycle. Rampant

poverty severely damages the structure needed to foster collective action to alleviate it. So, the pertinent question is: Is there a way out of this lingering conundrum? Theoretically yes, but practically no. The world does have credible and robust mechanisms and institutions to facilitate cooperation, but there is always a trade-off. When it comes to international relations, repeated interactions may assist in fostering cooperation and trust. But then, states today do not just negotiate on one issue. There is a wide array of issues that need to be addressed, and in this trade-off cooperation inevitably dwindles. Even systems designed to address uncertainties and disagreements crumble. Regarding communism, it is a lost cause anyway.

If we want to address poverty reduction, then the world has made strides. Iterated, as in repeated, interactions, a legal framework, transparency, and mandatory taxation or contributions like Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) have played a pivotal role in addressing poverty reduction. But curtailing the social mobility of defectors — people who encourage corruption — remains an everlasting challenge. So perhaps here, the goal could be promoting equity (fairness) rather than equality (sameness), because let us face the fact that not everyone is born equal, and if we put everyone on the same level playing field, some will inevitably outpace the rest.

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Supreme Court asks student arrested for Noida violence to approach HC



The Supreme Court on Friday refused to grant bail to a student accused of inciting violence during the industrial workers' protest in Noida on April 13. A bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan asked the counsel appearing for Aakriti Chaudhary to approach the Allahabad High Court. "Why don't you go to high court? Everybody comes here by filing petition under Article 32 of the Constitution. There are 93,000 cases pending in the Supreme Court," the bench observed.

The counsel appearing for Chaudhary submitted that grounds of arrest were not given by the police to the accused and sought bail. He told the apex court that Chaudhary is a student of Delhi University.

The top court also issued notice to police officials on a plea filed by one Keshaw Anand alleging torture by Uttar Pradesh police officials. A Noida court had earlier allowed conditional police remand of three women, Chaudhary, Manisha Chauhan and Srishti Gupta, accused of inciting violence during the industrial workers' protest on April 13. The court had also allowed their lawyers to be present during investigation proceedings. Chaudhary and Gupta are both from Delhi and in their 20s. Chaudhary has a masters in history from Daulat Ram College, while Chauhan is a worker with an industrial unit in Noida.

In the application for custody, police contended that there was "full possibility of getting important evidence from the place of residence of the accused". (PTI)

Excise policy: Delhi HC to hear CBI plea against discharge of Kejriwal, Sisodia on May 11

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday deferred hearing till May 11 on the CBI's petition challenging the trial court's discharge order in the liquor policy case, saying that it was awaiting consent of certain senior lawyers to represent AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma said she would pass the necessary order on the

appointment on Monday and begin hearing the matter on Tuesday. "There are three persons who are not represented. I am awaiting the consent of some persons who will be representing them.

"I will appoint on Monday... Arguments will begin on Tuesday," said Justice Sharma.

The former Delhi chief minister and MLAs have boycotted the hearing before Justice Sharma after the judge refused to recuse herself on

ADAG banking fraud requires thorough probe: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday said the matter concerning alleged large-scale banking fraud involving Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group and its firms required a "thorough investigation" after the CBI said the total loss estimated in seven cases was around ₹27,337 crore.

The CBI told the apex court nine FIRs had been lodged, including the two in which charge sheets have been filed, and investigations were on in seven cases.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi was hearing a PIL filed by former bureaucrat EAS Sarma who has sought a court-monitored probe into the alleged loan frauds exceeding ₹40,000 crore by the Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) firms led by industrialist Anil Ambani.

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioner, said it was "puzzling" that both the CBI and the Enforcement Directorate (ED)

have said it was a ₹27,000-crore scam and Anil Ambani was its "kingpin", but they have not arrested him so far. "Everywhere, the CBI and the ED are saying that in this ₹27,000-crore scam, Anil Ambani is the kingpin. Yet I find it very puzzling that neither the CBI nor the ED is willing to arrest him as if he is a holy cow," Bhushan said.

The bench observed that the apex court has repeatedly said that it would be extremely shy in directing arrest unless the investigating agency wants. It said rather than sensationalising the investigation, the focus should be on the probe and the collection of relevant materials.

The bench observed that the need for custodial interrogation in a case has to be left to the discretion of the probe agency.

"On the one hand, we want to develop jurisprudence like Antil and Pankaj Bansal (verdicts of the apex court), and if on the other hand we activate the investigating agencies like bloodhounds, it will be contrary to the law we are laying



down," the bench said. The top court said it was planning to monitor the probe as of now. Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Anil Ambani, questioned how the petitioner can have one of the charge sheets filed in the matter when the concerned court has not yet taken cognisance of it.

"His only agenda is to arrest Anil Ambani. How can he have a copy of the charge sheet when cognisance has not been taken?" Sibal said, adding that Anil Ambani was cooperating

in the investigation in every way. "Maybe I (Ambani) was cheated," Sibal said.

Bhushan made clear that the petitioner does not want anybody to be victimised.

The bench observed that it does not want any prejudice to be caused to either side.

"But the matter requires a thorough investigation and they (probe agencies) should do it in a timely manner so that there is public confidence," the bench said.

At the outset, Bhushan said the apex court had received

status reports of the CBI and the ED in a sealed cover on the last date of hearing.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for agencies, said two FIRs were registered against Reliance Telecom Ltd on complaints filed by the SBI.

"There are a total of nine FIRs out of which seven are under investigation and in two, charge sheets have been filed. In the seven cases, the total loss caused is ₹27,337 crore," he said.

Mehta said several teams of multiple investigating officers were formed for a speedy probe, and searches were conducted at 14 places in the seven cases in which a probe was going on.

He said 31 look out circulars have been issued and around 3,960 documents have been collected in these cases.

Mehta, while saying that two persons have been arrested so far in these cases, also gave a tentative timeline for the filing of charge sheets in these seven cases.

Bhushan said they have gone through a charge sheet

filed by the CBI in one of the cases and it was "so gross". "We can't really vet a charge sheet here," the CJI said. The bench said there was a stage when its intervention was required to activate the probe agencies and it passed appropriate orders.

It said that if the court finds that the investigation is lacking, it may step in further.

The bench noted that Mehta has given a brief note on the progress made in relation to the pending probe.

It posted the matter for further consideration in July.

Earlier, the apex court expressed displeasure over the "reluctance" shown by the CBI and the ED in probing the alleged large-scale banking fraud involving ADAG and its firms.

It had directed the CBI and the ED to conduct a "fair, dispassionate, transparent and time-bound" investigation into the matter. Anil Ambani had assured the top court that he would not leave the country without its prior nod after the petitioner apprehended that he may flee.

Congress MP Shashi Tharoor moves Delhi HC against publication of deepfake videos

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Congress MP Shashi Tharoor on Friday moved the Delhi High Court against the publication of AI-generated deepfake videos purportedly showing him "praising Pakistan" and making statements on such "politically sensitive" issues.

Justice Mini Pushkarna issued summons to social media platforms X and Meta Platforms as well as the Centre on the lawsuit by the Thiruvananthapuram MP and current chairperson of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs, and indicated she would pass an interim order in his favour.

Senior advocate Amit Sibal, appearing for Tharoor, submitted that unknown entities were repeatedly



publishing fake videos by misappropriating his face, voice and other attributes of his personality, which ought to be taken down.

The senior counsel argued that the videos are detrimental to Tharoor's reputation as a patriot and chairperson of the Parliamentary Standing Committee

on External Affairs. "India Today and PTI have put publicly that these are fake videos, yet the public continues to have the impression that the videos are genuine and authentic," he said.

"I am a former external affairs minister. It matters to India's standing as well... It is liable to be misused by foreign states," Sibal said, adding that even though the authorities took down several offending URLs pursuant to a grievance raised by Tharoor under the IT Rules and to the police, the content keeps re-surfacing.

Sibal emphasised that Tharoor is a public figure whose reputation is being tarnished by such deep-fake videos. Counsel for Meta submitted that the offending content on Instagram was made inaccessible this morning.

Delhi CM attack case: Court seeks report after accused allege assault inside jail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A court here on Friday sought a response from Tihar jail authorities on an application moved by two men accused of assaulting Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta last year, after they claimed they were beaten and issued death threats by fellow inmates.

Additional Sessions Judge Nishant Garg issued the notice while hearing a plea moved by the accused, Rajeshbhai Khimjibhai Sakariya and Tehsin Raza Sheikh.

The application was moved by Advocate Siddhant Malik on behalf of both the accused, who claimed that his clients' families were also getting threats.

"The said inmates have openly threatened the applicants/accused that they shall be killed inside the jail, they shall continue to be beaten till they 'learn a lesson', and their family members residing in Gujarat shall also be harmed," the application read.

The application sought directions for ensuring the safety and security of the two accused inside jail and



requested that they be shifted to a separate barrack.

"The applicants/accused were likely to be transferred to another jail where their safety would be at serious risk, and that a transfer list was about to be issued," it said.

Considering the application, the court issued a notice to the jail authorities and sought a status report by May 22, the next date of hearing.

It also directed the jail authorities to ensure the safety and security of the accused persons in custody.

In December last year, the court formally framed an attempt to murder charge against both the accused in the attack on Gupta at a public event in 2025, saying there was a prima facie case against them.

SC grants bail to murder convict after disturbing order passed by Orissa HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Taking note of a "disturbing order" passed by the Orissa High Court, the Supreme Court has granted bail to a murder convict while voicing serious concern over its approach which junked his appeal on the ground of delay.

A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and Ujjal Bhuyan said the High Court should have taken a "practical and sympathetic" view of the matter and condoned the delay to give an opportunity to the convict to argue his appeal on merits.

The top court noted that the convict has not been released even once on parole or furlough and said that sending the matter back to the high court to hear the criminal appeal on merits will be a futile exercise.



Supreme Court pulls up delays in witness examination in Lakhimpur Kheri case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday expressed disappointment over the non-production of witnesses in the ongoing trial against Ashish Mishra, son of former Union minister Ajay Mishra, and others in the 2021 Lakhimpur Kheri violence case.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi said the status report filed before it by the Uttar Pradesh Government has not assigned any reason whatsoever for the non-production of witnesses. It noted that no witnesses have been examined in the trial for the last two months.

"We direct the presiding judge to take lawful measures to secure the presence of witnesses," the bench said.

It asked the trial judge to make an endeavour to conclude the trial in a time-bound manner, and also to file a status report before it.

The trials in two cases related to the inci-



dent are going on before a court in Uttar Pradesh. The bench noted that in the first case, out of 131 witnesses to be examined, 44 have been examined, 15 have been discharged and 72 are still to be produced.

In the second FIR, out of 35 witnesses, 26 have been examined and nine were left, it said. Senior advocate Siddharth Dave, appearing for Ashish Mishra, said that as per the latest status report filed by Uttar Pradesh, 44 witnesses have been examined so far in the first FIR.

Bar has much to offer: CJI shares anecdote as he dismisses lawyer's plea for revaluation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a rare moment of candour, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant shared an anecdote when as a young lawyer he was rebuked by a high court judge for aspiring to become a judicial officer, and was told, "The bar is waiting for you."

The story came in a way of encouragement to a judicial services aspirant, who was seeking revaluation of an examination paper.

Though the plea of Prerna Gupta was dismissed by a bench comprising the CJI and Justice Joymalya Bagchi, she left the court smiling.

As Gupta pressed her case, the CJI intervened and said,



"Let me share my personal story and I hope you will go happily as we cannot allow your petition."

The CJI recounted his time as a final-year law student when he, too, wanted to become a judicial officer, had cleared the written test, and was to appear for the interview. "When I was in the final year, I applied for judicial services. At that time,

final-year students could apply. By the time the results came, the procedure had changed. Earlier, the public service commission used to conduct the selection. Then a Supreme Court judgment came, pursuant to which judges of the high court were to act as subject experts, and their opinion would be binding on the commission," he said.

The CJI recalled that around the same period, he had shifted to the Punjab and Haryana High Court and started practising there.

The senior-most judge on the interview panel happened to be the judge before whom he had recently argued two significant matters.

"The senior-most judge who had been nominated for the interview panel already knew me because I had argued two matters before him. One of the matters was Sunita Rani vs Baldev Raj, where he had allowed my appeal in a matrimonial case and set aside the decree of divorce granted by the district judge on the ground of schizophrenia," Justice Surya Kant shared.

"One day, he called me into his chamber and asked, 'Do you want to become a judicial officer?' I said yes. He immediately said, 'Get out from (my) the chamber.'"

The courtroom fell silent as he related the rebuke.

Supreme Court slams delay in action over remarks against Col Sofiya Qureshi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

"Enough is enough", an anguished Supreme Court observed on Friday as it asked the Madhya Pradesh Government to decide on granting sanction to prosecute its minister Kunwar Vijay Shah for his objectionable remarks targeting Army officer Col Sofiya Qureshi made in aftermath of Operation Sindoor.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi termed the objectionable statement of Shah as the "most unfortunate" after Solicitor General

Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state, said that the minister made "unfortunate" remarks and apologised quickly.

"What he said was definitely unfortunate," Mehta said. The CJI said, "Not unfortunate, but most unfortunate and then he has no sense of repentance also".

The unrelenting bench refused to hear further submission on behalf of Shah and the state and rather asked to comply within four weeks with its January 19 direction asking the Madhya Pradesh Government to take an appropriate decision regarding grant of sanction.



"Enough is enough. You comply with the directions given in paragraphs five and six of our previous order," the bench told the state and listed the matter after

summer vacation. At the outset, Mehta said the Special Investigation Team (SIT) has filed a report in the matter. Shah faced an apex court-appointed SIT probe for "scurrilous" and "objectionable" remarks targeting Col Qureshi.

Mehta, while clarifying that he was not defending Shah, said probably the minister intended to praise the officer but he ended up saying something else and could not articulate it properly. The top law officer said it was his personal view. "These political personalities, we know if they want to praise, how articulate they

are with their words," the CJI observed, adding that Shah could have soon tendered an apology if it was a slip of tongue.

Senior advocate Maninder Singh, appearing for Shah, said the minister had immediately issued an apology.

The bench said as per its January 19 order, the state was required to take decision on grant of sanction within two weeks. "Let the state take a call on this," the bench said. On January 19, the apex court noted that the SIT has completed its probe and submitted its final report.

However, further proceedings

have been stalled as the report awaits mandatory sanction from the state Government under Section 196 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), which deals with the promotion of communal hatred and ill-will.

The top court had opened and perused the SIT's sealed cover report, noting that the panel had sought the Government's sanction to prosecute him after investigating various aspects.

It had asked the SIT to make an endeavour to find out the details of the other instances attributed to Shah, a brief reference to which was made in the SIT report.

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Tata Trust meeting cancelled

A board meeting of Sir Ratan Tata Trust scheduled for Friday to reconsider nominations to the board of Tata Sons was cancelled for unspecified reasons, people with direct knowledge of the matter said.

The meeting was cancelled despite the Bombay High Court declining to stay the meeting of Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), which owns 23.6 per cent of Tata Sons, the holding company of the over \$180 billion Tata Group.

“The meeting did not happen. No reason was specified,” one of the persons said. No new date for the meeting has yet been informed.

An emailed query to Tata Trusts did not elicit a response. A petition had challenged the meeting, citing that the trust’s current board composition breached statutory limits introduced under the Maharashtra Public Trust (Second Amendment) Act, 2025.

It cited that SRTT currently has six trustees and three of them — Jimmy Naval Tata, Jehangir HC Jehangir, and Noel Naval Tata — are lifetime trustees, constituting 50 per cent of the board, exceeding the statutory ceiling of 25 per cent. The proposed meeting of the board of SRTT was reportedly called to discuss, among others, the reconsideration of Tata Trusts representatives on the Tata Sons board. (PTT)

Digital access, cyber security challenges in DPI ecosystem: Nageswaran

India’s Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) has achieved world-class scale, but challenges relating to digital access, data governance, interoperability and cyber security remain areas of concern, Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran said on Friday.

Addressing an ICRIER event on “Digital Public Infrastructure & Public Service Delivery”, Nageswaran said large sections of the population, particularly the elderly, people living in areas with poor connectivity and those with low literacy and limited digital fluency, still face barriers in accessing digital services.

“Digital infrastructure, however sophisticated, is not the same as digital inclusion in the fullest sense. The last great challenge of ensuring that those who most need services are also those who can most easily access them through digital means, that remains an ongoing effort,” Nageswaran said.

He said legislative and institutional framework in the area of data sharing and digital records is still evolving. Nageswaran said interoperability of DPI across states remains a “work in progress” and although Union Government systems are increasingly well integrated, the quality and completeness of state-level digital infrastructure varies considerably. (PTT)

India seeks greater role in global international space industry norms

India is seeking a larger role in shaping international norms for the fast-growing space industry, a senior Government official said on Friday, as global space standards experts gathered in New Delhi for a key ISO meeting.

The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) organised the 35th Plenary and Working Groups meetings of ISO’s Technical Committee 20/Subcommittee 14 on Space Systems and Operations, drawing 131 international delegates from 13 countries, including representatives from national standards bodies, space agencies, industry and academia.

In the opening session, Consumer Affairs Secretary Nidhi Khare said India stood “at the forefront of global space transformation”, citing policy reforms and the creation of IN-SPACE, a Government body set up to promote private sector participation in the country’s space sector, an official statement said.

BIS Director General Sanjay Garg said the organisation was working to align Indian standards with international frameworks, adding that the New Delhi venue gave domestic experts direct access to the global standardisation process. IN-SPACE Chairman Pawan Goenka stressed that robust standards were critical to enabling innovation and integrating India into the global space economy. The subcommittee develops international standards covering the full lifecycle of space systems, from design and production through launch and operations, with a focus on safety, interoperability and sustainability. (PTT)

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | MAY 9, 2026

BUSINESS11

Oil companies bleed as fuel prices hold steady

AMMAR ZAIDI ■ New Delhi

India’s State-run oil marketing companies have bled an estimated ₹30,000 crore in losses since mid-March as they kept fuel and LPG supplies flowing without raising retail prices despite facing an energy disruption that is bigger than all previous crises combined.

Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) have maintained uninterrupted supplies of petrol, diesel, LPG, aviation turbine fuel and other petroleum products since the start of the West Asia conflict, without raising retail prices despite a more than 50 per cent surge in input costs.

Their supply networks were stretched to the limit, as panic buying triggered a sharp spike in demand after the war disrupted traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, a key route for the majority of India’s energy imports. Yet there was no dry out or price increase.

In doing so, the three companies together incurred an estimated ₹30,000 crore in under-recoveries — the gap between input costs and realised retail prices — since mid-

March, two sources with direct knowledge of the matter said.

This loss would have swelled to nearly ₹62,500 crore had the Government not cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by ₹10 per litre each, they said.

Brent crude — the world’s most traded oil benchmark — was hovering around \$72 per barrel before the United States and Israel launched strikes on Iran on February 28, triggering a sharp escalation in West Asia tensions. Prices then surged as

reductions and absorption of part of the fuel cost burden. The Centre’s effective absorption at peak crude prices was estimated at around Rs 24 per litre for petrol and ₹30 per litre for diesel.

The special additional excise duty on petrol was cut to ₹3 per litre from ₹13, while excise duty on diesel was reduced to zero from ₹10 per litre.

Retail fuel prices in India have remained unchanged since February 28 despite the sharp rise in global crude prices, they said.

Daily under-recoveries during April were estimated at about ₹18 per litre on petrol and ₹25 per litre on diesel, translating into average losses of ₹600-700 crore a day for OMCs, they noted.

The companies also faced additional costs from emergency crude sourcing, higher freight charges due to vessel diversions, elevated marine insurance premiums and refinery optimisation expenses. Despite these pressures, fuel and LPG supplies remained uninterrupted across the country.

The surge in crude prices and the decision to shield consumers from higher retail prices placed significant strain on OMC balance sheets and refining margins, sources said.

They added that the measures reflected a policy decision to prioritise consumer stability and economic continuity during a global energy shock.

Sources warned that a prolonged period of elevated crude prices could lead to higher working capital borrowings and force some recalibration of capital expenditure plans. However, investments linked to refining expansion, energy security infrastructure, ethanol blending, biofuels and transition fuels would continue with Government backing, they said.

India’s approach contrasted with measures adopted by several other economies, where fuel prices rose sharply after the conflict-driven energy shock.

Petrol prices increased by about 34 per cent in Spain, 30 per cent in Japan, Italy and Israel, 27 per cent in Germany and 22 per cent in the United Kingdom, according to the estimates. Several countries also introduced rationing, conservation advisories, emergency relief packages or fuel caps.

In India, petrol prices remained ₹94.77 per litre and diesel at ₹87.67, with no rationing, mobility restrictions or supply disruptions, they added. (PTI)

World shares fall, oil prices dip

CHAN HO-HIMAP ■ Hong Kong

World shares retreated, and oil prices fell back on Friday as the fragile ceasefire with Iran was strained by missile and drone attacks that prompted US retaliatory strikes on Iranian military facilities.

US futures rose despite the latest flare-up in the conflict. The future for the S&P 500 gained 0.5 per cent, while that for the Dow Jones Industrial Average was up 0.3 per cent.

Investors are closely watching the war situation as negotiations between the US and Iran to end the war make limited progress. Tehran said on Thursday that it was still examining the latest proposals from the US for ending the war.

In early European trading, Britain’s FTSE 100 fell 0.7 per cent to 10,206.38. Germany’s

DAX shed 1 per cent to 24,417.08, while France’s CAC 40 dropped 0.8 per cent to 8,134.92.

Tokyo’s Nikkei 225 fell 0.2 per cent to 62,713.65 after closing the day before at an all-time high. Energy and technology giant SoftBank Group lost 4.6 per cent after soaring 18 per cent on Thursday.

Elsewhere in Asia, South Korea’s Kospi edged 0.1 per cent higher to 7,498.00, a

international standard, dipped 0.2 per cent to \$99.84 per barrel. Brent crude was roughly \$70 a barrel before the Iran war began in late February.

Benchmark US crude fell 0.5 per cent to \$94.34 a barrel. The US Central Command said on Thursday that it intercepted “unprovoked” Iranian attacks on Navy ships in the Strait of Hormuz, although no vessels were struck. But US President Donald Trump told reporters the ceasefire with Iran was still intact.

The United Arab Emirates, a US ally, said early Friday that its air defences were “actively engaging” with a missile and drone attack.

Oil and fuel prices are expected to remain elevated for as long as the Strait of Hormuz, a key waterway for oil and gas transit, remains largely closed, and a US sea blockade on Iranian ports continues. (AP)

Stock markets fall for 2nd day amid renewed tensions in West Asia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Equity markets stayed on the back foot for the second day on Friday as fresh geopolitical tensions in West Asia revived concerns over energy supplies and weighed heavily on investor sentiment.

Foreign fund outflows and a weak trend in global markets further added to the bearish trend.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 516.33 points, or 0.66 per cent, to settle at 77,328.19. During the session, it tumbled 698.09 points, or 0.89 per cent, to 77,146.43.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 150.50 points, or 0.62 per cent, to end at 24,176.15. From the Sensex pack, State Bank of India tanked 6.62 per cent after its March quarter earnings.

HDFC Bank, Bajaj Finance, Axis Bank, UltraTech Cement and Mahindra & Mahindra were also among the laggards. However, Titan jumped 4.76 per cent after the leading jewellery and watchmaker reported a 35.36 per cent increase in its consolidated net profit to Rs 1,179 crore for the March quarter of FY26.

Asian Paints, Adani Ports, Infosys and HCL Tech settled in the positive territory.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded around \$100 per barrel.

“Markets witnessed a risk-off session following fresh US-Iran military action near the Strait of Hormuz, which weakened ceasefire hopes and triggered profit booking. However, stability in crude oil prices around \$100 per barrel and benign US 10-year yields continue to provide support to the

broader sentiment and the rupee,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said. Though the road ahead is slightly bumpy, optimism around a possible diplomatic resolution persists, he added.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹340.89 crore on Thursday, according to exchange data.

In the previous session, Sensex ended 114 points lower at 77,844.52. The Nifty dipped 43.30 points to end at 24,326.65.

Court setbacks to Trump add uncertainty to US tariffs: Experts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Repeated setbacks faced by US President Donald Trump in American courts have further heightened uncertainty over the US tariff regime, and India should wait for the United States to evolve a more stable and legally predictable trade framework before moving ahead with the proposed bilateral trade agreement, experts said.

They said that this ruling is a crucial reminder that Trump’s global tariffs violated WTO (World Trade Organisation) rules, and their striking down by US courts is a positive signal for multi-lateral trade norms.

In another setback to the White House, a US federal court has struck down the 10 per cent global tariff tariffs slapped by Trump, terming them “invalid” and “unauthorised by law”.

These new tariffs were imposed by Trump on all countries, including India, on February 24 for 150 days following an earlier US Supreme Court verdict that struck down his earlier sweeping levies.

“The continuing uncertainty around US tariff policy, with major Trump-era tariffs repeatedly struck down by courts, makes any long-term trade commitments by India difficult to justify,” think GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

He said that India should wait until the United States develops a more stable and legally reliable trade system before concluding the Bilateral Trade Agreement.

“At present, the US is also not prepared to reduce its standard Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) tariffs, while expecting India to lower or eliminate its MFN duties across most sectors. Under such conditions, any trade deal risks becoming one-

sided, with India offering permanent market access concessions without receiving any meaningful tariff benefits in return,” Srivastava said.

Shishir Priyadarshi, President, Chintan Research Foundation, former Director, WTO, said that the federal court’s ruling is a crucial reminder that Trump’s global tariffs are in violation to the rules of the violated WTO rules, and their striking down is a positive signal for multi-lateral trade norms.

“However, with the decision held in abeyance, uncertainty lingers. We must remain vigilant, as the US may still seek new avenues to circumvent the ruling,” Priyadarshi said.

The United States Court of International Trade, in a 2-1 ruling on May 7, said the Trump administration had gone beyond the powers given by Congress under Section 122 of the Trade Act of 1974. It was struck down less than 50 days after they were introduced on February

20. According to the GTRI, the decision currently applies only to the parties that filed the case, the state of Washington, spice importer Burlap & Barrel, and toy maker Basic Fun!

“The tariffs will continue for other importers while the US Government appeals the ruling. The court chose not to block the tariffs nationwide at this stage. The court limited relief to the litigants before it rather than issuing a nationwide injunction, a practice sometimes followed by US courts in politically sensitive disputes involving executive authority,” Srivastava said.

With both the reciprocal tariffs and the Section 122 tariffs now invalidated by courts, the US tariff system is largely returning to its pre-Trump structure based on standard Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) tariff rates under the WTO framework.

Rupee falls 25 paise to close at 94.47 against US dollar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

The rupee depreciated 25 paise to close at 94.47 (provisional) against the US dollar on Friday, after rising in the past two sessions, on renewed tensions between the US and Iran over the Strait of Hormuz.

Forex traders said investor sentiments were affected after Iran accused the US of violating the ceasefire as the US carried out fresh attacks in the Strait of Hormuz and civilian areas, while President Donald Trump said the ceasefire was still in effect.

Brent oil prices, which had fallen to \$98 per barrel amid the US-Iran peace deal, edged higher to around \$100 per barrel as investors weighed the prospects for a Middle East peace deal.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.58 against the US dollar, then lost momentum and touched 94.68 against the American currency, registering a fall of 46 paise over its previous close.

At the end of closing on Friday, the rupee was quoted at 94.47 (provisional), down 25 paise over its previous close.

On Thursday, the rupee pared initial losses and settled the day on a positive note, up 27 paise at 94.22 against the greenback.

Forex traders said risk aversion in global markets and weak domestic equities also weighed on the rupee.

“We expect the rupee to trade with a slight negative bias amid renewed geopolitical tensions in the West Asia war. Recovery in crude oil prices and weak global markets may also pressurise the rupee.

“FII outflows may further drag the rupee lower.

However, we do not expect any major aggression. Traders may also take cues from non-form payroll data from the US. USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 94.10 to 94.90,” Anuj Choudhary, Research analyst at Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

On Friday, the United Arab Emirates responded to a missile and drone attack hours after the US said it thwarted attacks on three Navy ships in the Strait of Hormuz.

Iranian state media said the country’s forces exchanged fire with “the enemy” on Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz. It also reported loud noises and continuous defensive fire in western Tehran late Thursday night.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 97.91, down 0.15 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading lower by 0.25 per cent at \$99.81 per barrel in futures trade.

On the domestic equity market front, Sensex fell 516.33 points to settle at 77,328.19, while the Nifty dropped 150.50 points to 24,176.15.

Google exploring investments in India across AI infra: Vaishnav

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Internet giant Google is exploring investment opportunities across AI infrastructure, including the production of servers and drones, Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnav said on Friday. This announcement follows Google’s ground-breaking of its \$15 billion AI hub in Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh, in April this year.

“Google is exploring investments in India across AI infrastructure and the manufacturing of servers and drones,” Vaishnav said in a social media post after meeting company officials.

FROM THE WORLD

GERMANY

Police rescues two people

Police in Germany entered a bank in a small German town on Friday and rescued two people from a locked room, hours after officers were called to respond to a hostage situation.

Regional police said they were alerted to the situation at the Volksbank branch in Sinzig, a town of about 17,000 people in the Rhine valley near Koblenz, at about 9 am local time. They said they believed there were "several perpetrators and hostages" in the bank and the driver of an armoured van was a hostage. Shortly before 3 pm, police said special forces entered the bank and freed two people unhurt from a locked room. Police said they found no hostage-takers. They said that the perpetrators appeared to have left immediately after locking the two people into the vault, but it wasn't clear how that happened.

HUNGARY

Magyar to take oath as PM

As incoming prime minister Peter Magyar takes his oath of office within the halls of Hungary's sprawling neo-Gothic parliament on Saturday, thousands are expected to gather on a square just outside to celebrate the final moments of Viktor Orban's 16-year rule. Magyar's centre-right Tisza party defeated Orban's nationalist-populist Fidesz in a landslide victory last month, gaining more votes and seats in parliament than any other party in Hungary's post-Communist history. It was an earthquake mandate that will allow Tisza to roll back many of the policies that gave Orban a reputation among many of his critics as a far-right authoritarian, and to dig into the economic system.

Israeli airstrikes kill 5 in Lebanon; Hezbollah retaliates

BASSEM MROUE ■ Beirut

Israeli airstrikes on southern Lebanon killed at least five people on Friday, while Hezbollah fired rockets on northern Israel without inflicting any casualties.

The Health Ministry in Lebanon said that an Israeli airstrike on the southern village of Toura near the port city of Tyre killed four people and wounded eight. Lebanon's state-run National News Agency reported another airstrike near the southeastern village of Kfar Chouba, saying it killed a paramedic with the Lebanese Civil Defence.

The strikes came hours after the Israeli army's Arabic-language spokesperson issued an evacuation warning to the residents of six villages in Tyre province, including Toura. In the early afternoon,

Hezbollah fired a salvo of rockets toward northern Israel.

The Israeli military said it shot down one rocket while the rest fell in open areas without inflicting casualties. The latest exchange between Israel and Hezbollah, despite a ceasefire that has been in place since April 17, came two days after the first Israeli airstrike on Beirut's southern suburbs since the ceasefire went into effect.

The Israeli military said it had killed Ahmed Balout, who it identified as a commander in Hezbollah's elite Radwan Force, along with two other militants. There was no immediate comment from Hezbollah.

Israel says it has killed more than 85 Hezbollah militants and struck 180 sites used by the group in the past week, without providing evidence. On Friday, Lebanese President Joseph Aoun told a vis-



Rescue workers searching through the rubble of a building destroyed in an Israeli airstrike in Dahiyeh, Lebanon

AP

iting delegation from the European Union that European countries should pressure Israel to commit to the ceasefire and abstain from "detonating and bulldozing" homes in villages under Israeli occupation.

Aoun added in comments released by his office that Lebanon is committed to the ceasefire in order to start negotiations that will end the current conditions.

Hadja Lahbib, European Commissioner for Equality, told reporters after the meeting with Aoun that Israel and Hezbollah are taking Lebanon "hostage."

"Hezbollah should stop its attacks and disarm, and Israel should put limits to its airstrikes that target and have targeted humanitarian centres," Lahbib said. Aoun later met with Simon Karam, the head of the Lebanese

delegation to talks with Israel in Washington. The meeting is expected to be held in Washington on Thursday and Friday next week. The latest war between Israel and Hezbollah began on March 2, when Hezbollah fired rockets into northern Israel, two days after the United States and Israel launched a war on its main backer, Iran.

Israel has since carried out hundreds of airstrikes and launched a ground invasion of southern Lebanon, capturing dozens of towns and villages along the border. Later, Lebanon and Israel held their first direct talks in more than three decades. The two countries have formally been in a state of war since the founding of the state of Israel in 1948.

A 10-day ceasefire declared in Washington went into effect on April 17. (AP)

Starmer takes responsibility after UK local election losses

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Friday said he takes responsibility for the "very tough" losses for the Labour Party in the local election, which threw up big wins for the anti-immigration Reform UK.

Speaking to reporters as the vote count for Thursday's UK-wide polls for local councils and devolved Scottish and Welsh parliaments continues, Starmer said the outcome would not weaken his resolve to carry on tackling the challenges facing the country's economy.

He is faced with calls to quit as party leader and prime minister after Labour lost its majorities



in several key councils of Westminster, Southampton, Exeter, Redditch, Wandsworth, Hartlepool, Tamworth and Tameside.

"The results are tough, they are very tough, and there's no sugarcoating it," said Starmer. "We have lost brilliant Labour representa-

tives across the country, these are people who put so much into their communities, so much into our party. And that hurts, and it should hurt, and I take responsibility. "I'm not going to walk away and plunge the country into chaos," he said.

Asked if he would be the one leading the Labour Party into the next general elec-

tion, expected in 2029, he replied: "Yes. It was a five-year term I was elected to do, I intend to see that through."

However, the UK PM admitted that when voters "send a message like this", the governing party "must reflect and respond".

"They know the status quo is letting them down and they're frustrated, they don't feel the changes," he said. Meanwhile, the Nigel Farage-led Reform UK is celebrating significant gains in councils across England even as the results continue to trickle in.

The party has gained hundreds of councillors at the expense of both major parties, Labour and the Opposition Tories. "I think overall, what's happened is a

truly historic shift in British politics," Farage told reporters at Havering, the party's first major victory in a London borough. "We've been so used to thinking about politics in terms of Left and Right, and yet what Reform is able to do is to win in areas that have always been conservative. It's a big, big day not just for our party but for a complete reshaping of British politics in every way," he said.

In England, more than 4,500 councillors are being elected across 136 councils as well as some local borough mayors. In Scotland and Wales, where the count remains ongoing, voters are electing members of the Scottish Parliament, Welsh Senedd respectively. (PTI)



Forest fire burning in the exclusion zone around the Chernobyl nuclear power plant in Ukraine

AP

ASEAN adopts crisis plan amid Iran war concerns

JIM GOMEZ/JOEAL CALUPITAN ■ Cebu

Southeast Asian leaders adopted a contingency plan Friday to mitigate the impact of the Iran war on their people and economies but acknowledged it will be difficult to enforce complex steps like establishing a regional fuel reserve to ensure a steady supply.

The Philippines, among the worst affected by fuel price spikes caused by the Iran war, hosted the group's



President Ferdinand Marcos Jr

annual summit on the central island province of Cebu. President Ferdinand Marcos Jr ordered the summit stripped of the traditional

pomp and pageantry in keeping with the economic headwinds worldwide. ASEAN's contingency plan calls for actions including the ratification possibly this year of an agreement that will pave the way for coordinated emergency fuel sharing, planning a regional power grid and fuel stockpile and diversifying the region's sources of crude oil.

Promoting the use of electric vehicles and studying the use of new technologies, including civilian nuclear energy, were

also part of the crisis plan. The contingency steps will be implemented immediately but the establishment of a regional fuel stockpiled and power grid is a complex matter and may take a long time, Marcos said. "Let's talk about the fuel reserve. Is it going to be in one single place? Is it going to be scattered through the whole of ASEAN?" he asked. A regional power grid that allows countries to trade electricity has been considered for years but has only been realized "at a fairly small level," Marcos said, but added the leaders were unfazed. (AP)

6 killed, 13 injured as mortar shell hits civilian area in northwest Pak

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

At least six people were killed and 13 others injured when a mortar shell exploded in a civilian area in Pakistan's north-western Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, police said.

The incident took place in the Durrani Banda area of Hangu district when police were engaged in an operation against the terrorists who fired mortar shells that landed in the civilian area on Thursday, a police official said.

He said those killed included minors and young men, while women, children and



elderly persons were among the injured. The injured were shifted to a hospital in Hangu for treatment, while six critically injured were moved to hospitals in Kohat, he said.

The official said the operation was ongoing against the terrorists for the last 48 hours in the Zargari, Shnawari and Durrani Banda areas.

Nepal ready to resolve border issue with India through diplomatic channels: Chhetri

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal on Friday said it is committed to resolving the border issue with India through diplomatic channels.

"We have already made public our views regarding Lipulekh. We have also expressed our view regarding the proposed Kailash Mansarovar journey between India and China via Nepalese territory, Lipulekh," Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lok Bahadur Chhetri said. Nepal is willing to resolve the issue in accordance with the spirit of close



Lok Bahadur Chhetri

and friendly relations existing between Nepal and India, Chhetri said. "The Nepalese Government is always committed to resolving the border-related issue through diplomatic channels on the basis of historical agreements and understanding, facts, map and evidence," he added. His comments came days after India firmly rejected the Himalayan nation's objection to the upcoming Kailash Mansarovar Yatra via the long-established Lipulekh Pass in Uttarakhand, dismissing Kathmandu's territorial claims over the region as an "unilateral artificial enlargement" that New Delhi finds "untenable." New Delhi's sharp reaction came after the Nepalese foreign ministry objected to preparations by India and China for the annual pilgrimage via Lipulekh Pass, claiming the region belongs to it. (PTI)

कार्यालय, नगर पालिक निगम, कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)

ई-प्रोक्यूरमेंट निविदा सूचना

क. 379 निर्माण/2026 दिनांक 04.05.2026

एकीकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली अंतर्गत सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निम्नलिखित निर्माण कार्य हेतु (Online) आनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

क्र.	कार्य का विवरण	अनुमानित लागत (रु. लाख में)	निविदा डालने की अंतिम तिथि
1	नगर पालिक निगम कोरबा कोसाबाड़ी जोन अंतर्गत नाली, सड़क एवं भवन के पर्याप्त कार्य हेतु वार्षिक दर निर्धारण (परम्पत एवं संशोधन मय) (प्रथम निविदा)	100.00	25.05.2026 (T.No. 190208)

उपरोक्त कार्य की निविदा की जानकारी ई-प्रोक्यूरमेंट वेब पोर्टल <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है, साथ ही निगम के वेब साईट www.korbamunicipal.in पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

॥ स्वच्छ भारत निर्माण में योगदान दें ॥

अधीक्षक अभियंता
नगर पालिक निगम
कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)

Advt. 47820/2026
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NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-AUCTION NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Northern Railway Delhi Division invites bids through e-Auction through IREPS (<http://ireps.gov.in/>) for the allotment of under mention contracts at following Railway stations/locations:

E-Catalogue No.	Date & Time of bidding	Railway Stations/Locations/Lots
Parking-16-2026	25.05.2026 at 11:00 Hrs	Kirti Nagar PRS = Total 01 Site
MPS-MAY-01-26	25.05.2026 at 11:00 Hrs	New Delhi, Delhi, Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi Sarai Rohilla, Karnal, Modinagar, Meerut Cantt - Total 29 MPS Units.

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen. <https://ireps.gov.in/>

All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfill following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids:

1. Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module-Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module

2. Payment of One Time Registration Fee

3. Current Account in State Bank of India,

4. Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account.

5. Lien Marking of Funds.

6. Updation of Turnover Details.

7. Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors / Contractors (E-Tender /E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.

Railway Authority to contact, in case of any query

Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055
Email: pkg.delhidivision@gmail.com
Tel: 011-23743084

No.: 23AC/393/E-Auction/PKG/2026 Dated: 08.05.2026 1552/2026

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Invites application for **Professor:** Kayachikitsa (01), Panchkarma (01) **Lecturer:** Panchkarma (01), Shalya Tantra(01), Shalakya Tantra(02), Prasuti Tantra (02), Kaumarbhritya (01). **Eligibility & qualification:** As per NCISM/ university norms. Apply with detailed biodata & testimonials within 7 days from the date of publication on prescribed proforma, available on website www.davayurveda.com. alongwith self addressed stamped envelope

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The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Mohammad Faizan S/o. Abdul Rehman, R/o. 12-A/54, Street No.2, Vijay Mohalla, Mauipur, Delhi-110053, have declared that my name was mentioned in my 10th class mark sheet as Mohd Faizan instead of my actual name, Mohammad Faizan.

PD(1056)C

I, BIL BAHADUR GURUNG S/O BUDHU BAL GURUNG, R/o 73 B, L I G Indrapuram, Majra, Dehradun, Uttarakhand - 248171, have changed my name from VEER BAHADUR to BIL BAHADUR GURUNG for all other future purpose.

PD(1061)C

I, JUTHI DEVI W/o Veer Bahadur Gurung, R/o 73 B, L I G Indrapuram, Majra, Dehradun, Uttarakhand - 248171, have changed my name from GANGA DEVI to JUTHI DEVI for all other future purpose.

PD(1059)C

I, Kusum Singh, Mother of JC-473198A Sub Kiran Bahadur Singh, R/o- Teh- Sadar Faizabad, Tandauli, U.P. 224161, have changed my name from Kusum Singh to Kusum devi, vide affidavit dated 08/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1060)C

I, Sushma, W/o No.6498161P NK Chandra Bhushan Kumar, R/o- Vill- Mera, PO- Khanpura, PS-Khirimore, Teh- Paliganj, Dist-Patna, Bihar- 801110, have changed my name from Sushma to Sushma Devi, vide affidavit dated 08/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1062)C

I, Nagamani, Mother of No.15712543X Hav Kattunga Lakshmana Swamy, R/o- Vill & PO- Vasanthawada, Teh- Atrayapuram, Dist- East Godavari, Andhra Pradesh- 533235 have changed my name from Nagamani to Kattunga Nagamani, vide affidavit dated 08/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1063)C

I, Braj Mohan Prasad Singh, Father of JC-781655W Nb/Sub Priya Ranjan Kumar, R/o- Vill- Surhatha, Post- Bibipur, Dist- Vaishali, Bihar- 844111, declare that in my son's service record my D.O.B is wrongly mentioned as 01/07/1955 whereas my correct DOB is 28/11/1954 which may be amended accordingly.

PD(1063)C

Directorate of Small Savings & Lotteries

Government of Goa Serra Building, Altinho, Panaji Goa, 403001, India

No. 1-8-2025/DSSL/169 Dated: 08/05/2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (E-Tender Mode)

The Government of Goa, Directorate of Small Savings and Lotteries, Panaji, Goa hereby invites "Request for Bid" (RFB) under e-Tender Mode from interested and eligible Firms/Proprietorship concerns/Companies registered/LLP/Joint Venture or other legal entity Registered under the applicable law for selection and appointment as Marketing Agency for marketing and sale of Online or Paper or Both forms of lotteries for Set No. 1 and 2.

Interested Parties may obtain the e-Tender Document (RFB) through the website <https://eprocure.goa.gov.in> with effect from 08/05/2026.

a) Cost of Tender Document (Non-refundable) ₹2,00,000/- (Rupees Two Lakhs only),

b) Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of ₹50,00,000/- (Rupees Fifty Lakh only) per set the bidder is bidding.

c) Tender processing fee ₹6,000/- (Rupees Six Thousand only).

1. The desirous bidders who have not registered with eProcurement portal and intending to participate in the e-tender shall have to register on <https://eprocure.goa.gov.in> and apply before the last date of application.

2. The prescribed RFB document duly filled in along with all the requisite certificates/documents etc. as per the requirements of the tender conditions shall be submitted online under e-tendering mode on or before 25/05/2026 upto 04:30 p.m. The Applications received after the prescribed date and time shall not be entertained.

Sd/- (Dasharath M. Redkar) Director

DI/ADVT/366/2026

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER: PWD: H&E: ASSAM: CHANDMARI: GUWAHATI-3

No. CE/TB-IV(H&E)/50/2025/19

PRESS NOTICE (RE-TENDER)

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D. (Health & Education), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3 on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites fresh Bids online e-tenders in two bid system (Eligibility and Financial) from eligible firms / contractors of repute having experience in similar nature of work, for the following works.

Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement website i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in.

The bidders must be enrolled with e-tendering web-portal www.assamtenders.gov.in.

All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents. The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents.

Sl. No	Name of work	Bid Value (Rs in Lakhs)	Completion Period	Bid Security	Cost of Bid
1	Construction of Model Secondary Schools in Tea Garden Areas, Assam at Bahadur T.E., Dist.: Tinsukia	Rs. 292.03812	18 (Eighteen) months	2% of Bid value for General, 1% of Bid Value for Reserve category	Rs. 5850.00

The Bid price may vary at the time of detail tendering for which no claim will be admissible. The Tender will be valid subject to approval from Secondary Education Department, Dispur.

Sd/- Chief Engineer (Health & Education), PW (H&E) Deptt., Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/4/9-May-26

Europe still needs US support: Italy tells Rubio

GIADA ZAMPANO
■ Rome

Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani said he told US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Friday that Europe needs the United States, and vice versa, as America's top diplomat wrapped up two days of fence-mending talks in Italy and the Vatican following weeks of tensions over the US-Israeli war in Iran.

Tajani reaffirmed strong trans-Atlantic ties and said he hoped "tensions have been calmed" with Rubio's visit.

He said the two discussed the Iran war and spillover into Lebanon, as well as the situation in Venezuela and Cuba. The US secretary of state also met Friday with



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio meeting Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani during his two-day visit to Italy and the Vatican in Rome

Premier Giorgia Meloni. "I believe things can go in the right direction," Tajani said. "I am convinced Europe needs America — Italy needs America — and the United States also needs Europe

and Italy." President Donald Trump's tariffs, his complaints about Europe's unwillingness to help the US with the Iran war and his attacks on Pope Leo XIV have fueled weeks of sharp dis-

agreements over trade and defence cooperation between the two traditionally strong allies.

Tajani reaffirmed Friday that Italy stood ready to send in its navy to help demine the Strait of Hormuz once a permanent ceasefire is reached with Iran, and to maintain its already strong presence in Lebanon with the UN peace-keeping mission.

He said he told Rubio that Italy considers the presence of US troops in Europe to reinforce NATO important, a reference to Trump's threats to pull back America's troops. The State Department, for its part, said Rubio raised efforts to "promote freedom of navigation and maritime securi-

ty," as well as a need for an end to the war in Ukraine, and for Western nations to protect their economic interests. Trump has criticised both the Pope and Italy's government for opposing the Iran war.

Meloni has called the US-Israeli bombing "illegal" and rebuked Trump's remarks about the pontiff as "unacceptable." Trump has responded by accusing Meloni of lacking courage and being "negative" on helping the US with the war. Meloni had long been seen as one of Trump's top allies in Europe, but Trump has openly said their relationship has cooled.

Italy remains firmly opposed to the war with

Iran The US has announced a decision to pull 5,000 military personnel from Germany, and Trump has threatened to withdraw more troops from Italy and Spain over their stance on the war.

Italy, a key logistics hub for US and allied operations in the Mediterranean, the Middle East and North Africa, could see its role affected if troop levels are reduced, raising concerns about NATO's posture in southern Europe. Defence cooperation was already tested in late March, when Italy declined to allow US bombers bound for the West Asia to land at Sigonella base in Sicily without Government approval. (AP)

Former CEO of SriLankan Airlines found dead at home



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Former CEO of SriLankan Airlines Kapila Chandrasena was found dead at his home in suspicious circumstances on Friday, days after he secured bail in a corruption case, police said.

Chandrasena was granted bail on Tuesday after he was remanded in March in the case where he was charged for taking a kickback on the purchase of aircraft for the national carrier.

Assistant Superintendent of Police (ASP) FU Wootler said that his body was discovered at his home. According to the police spokesman, he died of hanging, Daily Mirror newspaper reported.

The development comes a day after Colombo Chief Magistrate Asanga S Bodaragama issued a warrant for Chandrasena's arrest over allegations that the bail conditions imposed by the court had been violated. Prosecutors told the Colombo Chief Magistrate's Court that SriLankan Airlines' former CEO Kapila, the chief accused in the case, admitted to giving LKR 60 million in bribes to former president Mahinda Rajapaksa.

Hundreds protest Nepal plan to remove squatters in Kathmandu

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

Hundreds of landless squatters on Friday staged a demonstration protesting the Balendra Shah Government's recent move to bulldoze their structures in various parts of the country, including in Kathmandu.

More than 3,500 structures belonging to landless squatters have been demolished by the federal Government in Kathmandu and hundreds of other settlements since last month in different districts outside the capital city for beautification and environmental protection. Nepal's Supreme Court on May 4 ordered the government to submit the



details of procedures followed in demolishing squatters' settlements in the Kathmandu Valley.

On Friday, carrying empty plates and raising slogans demanding their right to live and housing, the protesters — organised under the Joint Landless Squatters forum — gathered at

Maitighar Mandala in the heart of the capital city.

"End the displacement drive in the name of development," "Where will you wash the hands tainted with the blood of squatters?," "Give us justice, not displacement," were the slogans raised and captions of the placards on the occa-

sion. The federal Government and the Kathmandu Metropolitan City jointly evicted thousands of landless squatters from various parts of Kathmandu including Thapatali, Gairigaun, Manahora, Balaju, Anamnagar Sinamangal and Kapan areas displacing around 20,000 people.

The Government shifted a few hundred squatters in holding centres in Kirtipur, Bhaktapur and some hotels on temporary basis, despite which, hundreds of squatters are still staying in open sky in miserable condition even when the pre-monsoon rains have started across the country, said Saraswati Karmacharya, a

journalist associated with Nepal Samacharpatra. There is a risk of starvation of hundreds of landless squatters, who are forcibly evicted from their settlements, she pointed out.

Opposition parties have also criticised the government on the ground that thousands of landless squatters were evicted from Kathmandu and other major parts of the country without properly collecting their data and with alternative settlement plans.

In a related development, people protested the notice circulated by Kshireswor Municipality of Dhanusha district in Madhes Province, to vacate the public land occupied by squatters in that area. (PTI)

Man charged with harassing Andrew near his home

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

A man has been charged with harassing Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor after reports that the former Prince Andrew was threatened by a masked man while walking dogs near his home.

Alex Jenkinson, 39, is due at Norwich Magistrates Court on Friday to face two counts of using threatening, abusive or insulting words or behaviour to harass someone or cause alarm or distress. Norfolk Constabulary announced the charges on Thursday night. Police said the



suspect was arrested Wednesday evening after a man was reported "behaving in an intimidating manner" near Andrew's home in eastern England.

The Daily Telegraph newspaper reported that a man wearing a ski mask ran toward the former royal while shouting abuse.

3 hikers killed by volcano eruption in Indonesia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Jakarta

An explosive eruption of Mount Dukono on a remote Indonesian island killed three hikers, authorities said on Friday.

About 20 climbers set out Thursday to ascend the nearly 1,355-meter (4,445-foot) volcano on the island of Halmahera, in defiance of safety restrictions, said North Halmahera police chief Erlichson Pasaribu.

They became stranded when Dukono erupted at 7.41 am local time, spewing a thick ash column that rose about 10 kilometres



(6.2 miles) above the summit. The eruption was recorded on seismographs for more than 16 minutes, Indonesia's Geological Agency said.

"They were aware that climbing was prohibited as the mountain is a restricted zone due to its high alert

status, but insisted on going ahead," Pasaribu said in a television interview.

Rescue teams were deployed after receiving an emergency signal from the mountain area.

Three men — two Singaporean and one Indonesian national — died at the scene, Pasaribu said. As of Friday afternoon, 14 climbers, including seven foreign nationals, had been safely evacuated.

Five of those evacuated were reported injured. Rescue teams continued to search for other climbers believed to be attempting to descend.

Bulgarian Parliament confirms Radev as new PM

SOFIA (BULGARIA)
■ London

Bulgaria's Parliament on Friday formally approved Rumen Radev as the new prime minister in a bid to end political instability and spur economic development in the EU member country.

"We have no illusions about the crises and trials facing the government, which will soon be seeking your support — galloping prices, budget, missing reforms, a severe global energy crisis and escalating conflicts," Radev told lawmakers.

The chamber voted 124-70 with 36 abstentions to elect Radev, a 62-year-old former president, as prime minister. Radev resigned from the mostly ceremonial presiden-



cy in January, a few months before the end of his second term, to launch a bid to lead the government in the more powerful role as prime minister. Bulgaria's previous conservative government collapsed in December after

nationwide anti-corruption protests drew hundreds of thousands of mainly young people to the streets.

Radev's popularity surged as he cast himself as an opponent of the entrenched mafia and their ties to high-

ranking politicians. At campaign rallies he vowed to "remove the corrupt, oligarchic model of governance from political power".

His Progressive Bulgaria party scored a landslide victory in the April 19 parliamentary election, giving it a comfortable majority, with 131 seats in the 240-seat legislature. Radev, a former fighter pilot, earned a Master of Strategic Studies degree from the US Air War College in 2003, before being appointed Bulgarian air force commander.

His supporters are divided between those hoping he will put an end to the country's oligarchic corruption and those lining up behind his eurosceptic and Russia-friendly views. (AP)

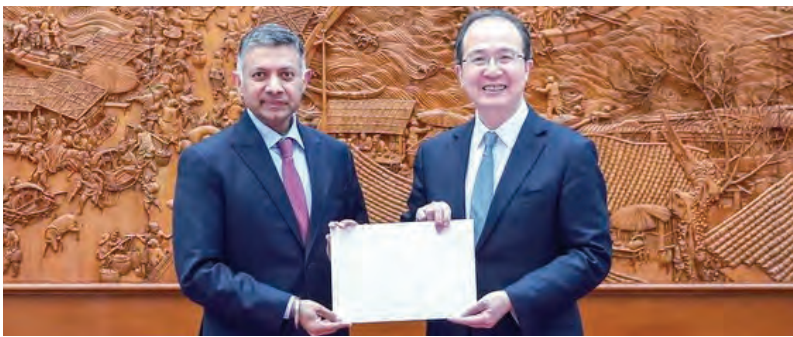
India's new envoy to China presents credentials to Assistant Foreign Hong

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

India's new envoy to China Vikram Doraiswami has presented a copy of his credentials to Assistant Foreign Minister Hong Lei.

Doraiswami also took part in the commemoration ceremony of the first anniversary of the Operation Sindoor held at the embassy.

Ambassador Doraiswami presented a copy of his credentials to Assistant Foreign Minister and Director-General of the Protocol Department of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, HE Hong Lei, in Beijing, an Indian Embassy post on X said. "Gathered to salute the professionalism of our armed forces who displayed unparalleled courage, precision



and resolve. The officials remembered the innocent victims of the dastardly Pahalgam terror attack and reiterated their resolve to fight terrorism in all its forms and manifestations," the embassy post said.

Doraiswami, a 1992-batch Indian Foreign Service officer, was accorded a warm welcome by senior Chinese and Indian officials when he arrived in Beijing last Sunday to take up his new assignment.

Paraguay, Taiwan reaffirm ties after China sought to lure away another Taipei ally

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Taipei (Taiwan)

Paraguay's President Santiago Pena said on Friday that his country deeply values its ties with Taiwan, in a show of solidarity with the island democracy, a day after Beijing asked the South American nation to sever diplomatic relations with Taipei.

Paraguay is the only country in South America to recognise Taiwan and one of just 12 worldwide. Beijing

values such as democracy, freedom and human rights, it will continue to support Taiwan and promote a bilateral strategic partnership.

"Paraguay highly values the relationship," the interpreter quoted him as saying outside the Taiwan presidential office. Taiwan's President Lai Ching-te thanked his counterpart and Paraguay's government for speaking out for Taiwan and firmly supporting Taiwan's international participation.



considers Taiwan its own territory and has ramped up a campaign over the past few years to lure Taiwan's diplomatic allies, in addition to increasing military pressure around the island. At a military honours event, Pena said the ceremony symbolises the unwavering determination between both sides to continuously deepen their ties and partnership, according to an interpreter. He said based on the foundation of shared

"I believe the friendship between Taiwan and Paraguay will further deepen and their cooperation will become closer through the visit of President Pena," Lai said. The reaffirmation of ties came after Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson Lin Jian on Thursday urged Paraguayan authorities to "come to the right side of history as soon as possible" and sever diplomatic ties with Taiwan.

Pope marks election anniversary with Pompeii shrine visit



PAOLO SANTALUCIA/
NICOLE WINFIELD
■ Pompeii (Italy)

Pope Leo XIV spent the first anniversary of his election on Friday by praying in the ancient city of Pompeii, commemorating a Marian feast day that is particularly important to him, which coincided with the start of his pontificate. Leo travelled by helicopter to Pompeii, near Naples, for a daylong visit to mark the May 8 feast of Our Lady of Pompeii.

The date marks the day in 1876 when the cornerstone for a shrine dedicated to the Virgin Mary in Pompeii was laid. The sanctuary is located near the excavations of the city that was buried in AD 79, when Mount Vesuvius erupted and spewed volcanic ash and gas across the region. While the Pompeii archaeological site draws millions of tourists each year, the sanctuary attracts Catholic pilgrims who are particularly devoted to praying the rosary. (AP)

Public Notice / General Information

The general public is hereby informed that my client is lawfully purchasing the below-described land/property/agricultural land from 1. Sh. Atar Singh-Dharmender-Ved Prakash all Ss/o Sh. Gayasi R/o Village Nagalia, Tehsil & District Palwal, Haryana, 2. Mrs. Jyoti Gaur W/o Mr. Dheeraj Bhati R/o Village Bagpur Kalan (191), Palwal, Haryana-121004, 3. Mrs. Geeta, W/o Mr. Satpal, Ms. Priyanshi D/o Mr. Satpal, Ms. Vidhi D/o Mr. Satpal all are R/o Village Mohna, Tehsil Mohna, District Faridabad, Haryana-121004, 4. Sh. Rakesh-Raj Kumar-Jasveer Singh-Satveer Singh all Ss/o Sh. Rajender R/o Village Siroli, Banger, Tehsil Jewar, District Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P.-203209, 5. Mrs. Sunita W/o Sh. Vishnu Singh R/o Village Shaikhpur, P.O. Mohna, Palwal, Haryana-121102 ("Seller").

Sh. Atar Singh-Dharmender-Ved Prakash are having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No. 30/34, Rect. No. 42, Killa No. 6/1, 15, 16 and Khewat/Khata No. 31/35, Rect. No. 42, Killa No. 8 and Khewat/Khata No. 32/36, Rect. No. 42, Killa No. 6/2, 7, 13, 14, 17/1, 18, 23/1 situated at Nagalia, Tehsil & District Palwal, Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2021-2022.

Mrs. Jyoti Gaur having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No. 108/1/116/1, Rect. No. 41, Killa No. 11/1 and Khewat/Khata No. 110/118, Rect. No. 42, Killa No. 25/2, situated at Village Nagalia, Tehsil & District Palwal, Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2021-2022 and Khewat/Khata No. 533/577-578-579-580-581, Rect. No. 51, Killa No. 9/1, 12, 18, 22, 23, Rect. No. 66, Killa No. 1, 8, 2, 3, Rect. No.51, Killa No. 11, 13, 14, 19, 20, 21, Rect. No.52, Killa No. 15, 16, 25/1, Rect. No.66, Killa No. 1, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 18, Rect. No.67, Killa No.20/2, situated at Village Bagpur Kalan, Tehsil & District Palwal Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2021-2022.

Mrs. Geeta, Ms. Priyanshi, Ms. Vidhi are having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No. 33/48, Rect. No. 15, Killa No. 17/2, 24/1, Rect. No. 18, Killa No.4/2, 5, 7, situated at Jhuppa, Tehsil & District Palwal, Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2019-2020.

Mr. Rakesh, Mr. Raj Kumar, Mr. Jasveer Singh, Mr. Satveer Singh are having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No. 57/98, Rect. No. 1, Killa No. 25, Rect. No.2, Killa No. 21, Rect. No.3, Killa No. 1, Rect. No.4, Killa No.1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 20, Rect. No.5, Killa No.3, 4, 6, 7, 8, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18/1, 24, 25, Rect. No.12, Killa No. 4, situated at Village Jhuppa, Tehsil & District Palwal, Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2019-2020.

Mrs. Sunita having share in the land as details hereunder in Khewat/Khata No. 29/33, Rect. No. 33, Killa No. 1, 2, 3/1, 8, 9, 10, 11/1, 12, 13, 18, 19, 23/1 situated at Nagalia, Tehsil & District Palwal, Haryana, as per Fard Jamabandi for the year 2021-2022. The above said person have agreed to sell their entire respect shares in the aforesaid Khewat(s)/Khanton(s) to my Client (hereinafter collective share of all is referred as "Scheduled Property/Land")

The Seller has declared that the said Scheduled Property/Land is completely free from all kinds of encumbrances including but not limited to charges, mortgages, loans, claims, disputes, litigations, attachments, stay orders, ceiling proceedings, acquisition, surplus land, government dues, or any third-party rights or claims whatsoever, and that the title of the Scheduled Property/Land is clear, clean, and marketable. The Seller has further represented and warranted that the Seller has clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership and is in actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession of the said Scheduled Property/Land and that no prior, existing, or subsisting agreement, transaction, understanding, or arrangement of any nature whatsoever, whether oral or written, in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land has been entered into with any third party in respect thereof. It has also been declared that no case, proceeding, or dispute in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land is pending before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

Therefore, any person, bank, financial institution, government department, or any other party, firm, company, or entity, who has or claims to have any valid, legal, or equitable right, title, interest, claim, demand, charge, or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land—whether by way of sale, gift, lease, tenancy, license, exchange, partition, mortgage, lien, inheritance, succession, agreement, litigation, decree, stay order, possession, or otherwise—shall intimate the undersigned in writing, along with full particulars of such claim/object and supporting documentary evidence, within fifteen (15) days from the date of publication of this notice.

In case no information or objection is received within the stipulated period, it shall be conclusively and lawfully presumed that there exists no encumbrances including but not limited to third-party claim, right, or dispute etc. in respect of the said Scheduled Property/Land, and my client shall be free to proceed with and complete the proposed sale transaction with the Seller and shall be legally deemed to have clear, valid, absolute, and marketable right, title, interest and ownership therein along with actual, vacant, peaceful physical and legal possession thereon, entitling my Client to lawfully proceed with and complete the proposed sale transaction of the Scheduled Property/Land with the Seller. Thereafter, any such claim, objection, or dispute shall be treated as legally untenable, deemed to have been waived, and my client shall not be held liable for the same in any civil or criminal proceedings before any court, tribunal, or any competent legal or quasi-legal authority/forum.

The Scheduled Property/Land shall be deemed to include all rights, easements, pathways, appurtenances, standing crops, trees, plants, constructions, fences, boundary walls, etc. attached thereto.

The general public is hereby cautioned not to deal or enter into any transaction concerning the Schedule Property/Land with any person, party, or entity, failing which such transaction shall be at their own cost, risk and consequences.

This public notice is issued on behalf of my Client with complete bona-fide, transparency, and good faith so as to safeguard my client against any future allegations of fraud, misrepresentation, or collusion or any other allegations whatsoever in relation to the Schedule property. This notice is being issued without prejudice to any of the legal rights, contentions and remedies available to my client under applicable law.

Durga Lal - Advocate, Law Consultant Office,

Office No. 57 Nehru Ground Near Main Post Office,
B.K. Chowk, NIT Faridabad, Haryana. ENROL. No. PH/5563/2022
Mobile No.7303834091, Email- lawconsultantsoffice@gmail.com

Indian Army marks 1st anniversary of Operation Sindoor at Manipur University

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Commemorating the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor, the Indian Army organised a community outreach and awareness programme at Manipur University on Thursday to engage students and faculty members on issues related to national security, terrorism, and information warfare.

The event, attended by students and faculty from the Department of National Security Studies, focused on sensitising participants about the role of the Armed Forces in safeguarding the sovereignty and integrity of the nation and countering terrorism.

The programme began with an interactive session in which Army representatives revisited the objectives and operational



aspects of Operation Sindoor. Officials highlighted the significance of the operation and encouraged informed discussions on national security challenges and strategic preparedness.

As part of the outreach initiative, the Army conducted awareness sessions and discussions aimed at promoting greater understanding of information warfare and the growing importance of responsible

digital conduct. Participants were encouraged to act as "responsible information warriors" in protecting national interests in the evolving information landscape. The event witnessed

active participation from students and faculty members, who engaged in discussions, raised queries, and exchanged perspectives on contemporary security issues. Organisers said the interaction reflected increasing academic interest in defence and strategic studies.

According to the Army, the outreach programme was conducted in the spirit of community engagement and national awareness. The initiative also sought to strengthen collaboration between the Armed Forces and academic institutions while promoting peace, harmony, and inclusive development in the region.

The event reaffirmed the Indian Army's continued commitment to public outreach and strategic awareness-building among the youth, particularly in the Northeast.

Pune cleantech startup Novorbis Itus bags ₹13.35 cr seed funding from Rainmatter

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Pune-based cleantech startup Novorbis Itus Pvt Ltd has raised ₹13.35 crore in a seed funding round led by Rainmatter, the investment arm of Zerodha, with participation from Rockstud Capital.

Founded by Harsh Neekhra, Gagan Tripathi and Divyank Gupta, the startup develops emission control and air purification technologies aimed at reducing pollution from decentralised sources such as diesel generator (DG) sets and crematoriums.

The company's key offerings include a filter-less Retrofit Emission Control Device (RECD) designed for existing DG sets and the Crematorium Air Purification System (CAPS), which aims to curb emissions from crematorium operations.

According to the company, the newly raised capital will be used to scale deployments of its technologies, expand its



product portfolio to sectors such as boilers, steel plants and industrial facilities, and support the development of on-site carbon capture solutions.

The funding transaction was advised by Indorient Financial Services Ltd.

Commenting on the development, CEO Harsh Neekhra said the company was founded with the goal of addressing air pollution at its source. "We started Novorbis Itus as second-year college students in Indore with an idealistic view to fix air pollution at its source and leave clean air for future genera-

tions. With this investment, we aim to scale our technology and accelerate adoption across sectors," he said.

Abhinav Negi said the startup is addressing critical but underserved pollution challenges in India. "DG set emissions and crematorium pollution tick all boxes—urgent, undeniable, and underserved. Novorbis is solving both with technology built for Indian conditions," he noted.

Abhishek Agrawal said that tightening environmental norms are increasing the importance of retrofit emission control technologies.

PROSPECT

RGCIRC holds campaign on World Thalassaemia Day



Marking World Thalassaemia Day 2026, RGCIRC (Rajiv Gandhi Cancer Institute & Research Centre) organised an awareness and screening initiative to address the rising burden of thalassaemia in the National Capital Region. Addressing the gathering, Dr Gauri Kapoor, Director – Pediatric Haematology, Oncology & BMT, RGCIRC, highlighted the scale of the challenge and the need for a proactive approach. "Delhi is increasingly being recognised as one of the global hubs of thalassaemia due to the high number of cases we see.

This makes awareness and prevention not just important, but urgent. The disease is entirely preventable with the right screening measures, yet many families remain unaware until it is too late," she said. A key focus area of the event was strengthening awareness around carrier detection through High-Performance Liquid Chromatography (HPLC) testing, a simple yet effective diagnostic tool. According to experts, when both partners are carriers of thalassaemia minor, there is a 25 per cent chance that their child will have thalassaemia major.

GoC Spear Corps reviews operational preparedness in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

Lieutenant General Girish Kalia, General Officer Commanding (GOC) of the Spear Corps, visited forward areas and key military garrisons across Manipur on Thursday to assess the prevailing security situation, operational preparedness, and capability enhancement initiatives being undertaken by troops deployed in the State.

During the visit, Lt Gen Kalia conducted an aerial reconnaissance of areas affected by the recent Tangkhul-Kuki clashes to review the evolving security dynamics in the region. He later visited forward Army locations at Kangvai, Sendra, Litan and YKPI, where he interacted with commanders and personnel stationed on the ground.

The GOC commended troops for their professionalism, operational vigilance, and commitment towards maintaining peace and stability in sensitive areas of the State.

As part of his engagements, Lt Gen Kalia also



visited Somsai and Kakching Garrison along with the Inspector General Assam Rifles (South) and other senior officials, underlining the close coordination among security agencies operating in the region.

At Somsai, Army officials briefed the GOC on the security situation in Ukhrul and Kamjong districts.

He appreciated the formation for maintaining a high degree of operational readiness in strategically important and sensitive areas.

At Kakching Garrison, Lt Gen Kalia reviewed ongoing

counter-insurgency operations, emerging security challenges, and measures being implemented to enhance operational capabilities. He praised the sustained efforts of troops in responding effectively to evolving threats and ensuring stability in the region.

A major focus of the visit was the Army's growing emphasis on technology-driven warfare capabilities. At the Red Shield Drone Lab in Leimakhong Military Station and the Drone Training Laboratory at Kakching, the GOC reviewed indigenous drone

assembly, repair, and specialised drone warfare training initiatives being developed by troops.

He also witnessed demonstrations of in-house innovations designed to improve surveillance, operational efficiency, and troop effectiveness in Manipur's difficult terrain.

Lt Gen Kalia lauded the Army personnel for adopting a futuristic approach to modern warfare and commended their technical expertise in developing mission-oriented drone solutions tailored to operational requirements.

CPHI & PMEC India 2026 expands to dual venues in Delhi-NCR for 19th edition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The 19th edition of CPHI India 2026 and PMEC India 2026 will be hosted across two separate venues in Delhi-NCR next year, marking a major expansion of one of India's leading pharmaceutical industry events.

Organisers announced that the expanded format aims to accommodate the growing scale of India's pharmaceutical and manufacturing ecosystem while providing greater engagement opportunities for exhibitors and visitors.

Under the new arrangement, CPHI India - focused on pharmaceutical ingredients, active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs), and formulations — will be held from November 23 to 25 at IICC Yashobhoomi in New Delhi.

PMEC India, which focuses on pharmaceutical machinery, engineering, and manufacturing technologies, will take place from November 24 to 26 at India Expo Mart.

The overlapping schedules are expected to create a continuous four-day industry



engagement platform for stakeholders across the pharmaceutical value chain.

According to the organisers, CPHI India will continue to serve as a global platform for international sourcing, partnerships, and pharmaceutical trade, while PMEC India will provide expanded exhibition space for showcasing advancements in automation, cleanroom technologies, packaging systems, and manufacturing solutions.

Yogesh Mudras said the decision to expand the event into dual venues was driven by increasing industry demand for more space and deeper business interactions.

DAILY SUDOKU

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693

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1

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4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (8.5.26)

3	2	6	7	1	9	4	5	8
4	9	1	5	2	8	3	6	7
7	8	5	3	6	4	2	1	9
6	5	8	9	3	7	1	4	2
9	7	3	2	4	1	6	8	5
1	4	2	8	5	6	9	7	3
5	1	9	6	8	2	7	3	4
2	3	4	1	7	5	8	9	6
8	6	7	4	9	3	5	2	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
SATURDAY | MAY 9, 2026

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32

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33

ACROSS

1 Fool around for a quarter hour in the bathroom (6)

7 Conventional piece of work, a book about the North (8)

8 Henry left the building (4)

10 In the position to plead wildly, keeping a cool head (6)

11 With hearty Jethroe, I have to do well (6)

14 It doesn't quite rate being petted (3)

16 Heavy reading (5)

17 Finds the total for the drinks (4)

19 Will Halley's arrive on Tuesday? (5)

DOWN

1 Flabby and a bit wet, it clings to a rock (6)

2 Squabble, reversing a car in furious extremities (6)

3 Keep below decks (4)

4 The opposite of wronged? (7)

5 Nominally a large figure (5)

6 Impressive characters? (5)

8 Wild animal that gets right into your straw, possibly (4)

9 Occupied in wholesale trade (3)

12 Tommy's tosh? (3)

13 Exotic vines apt to bleed when cut (5)

15 Rationale shown in the record, I see (5)

18 On line to get ahead with something

15 Limit

16 Te-Lis

18 Devil

19 Box-ween

21 Airily

6 Re-late-d

7 Oral

8 Merlin

12 Major

26 Tim-a

28 Moo

19 B-Q-X-ed

20 Fall-er

22 Fill

24 His

25 Pirates

26 Twill

27 Dik-I-e

28 Minus

29 New moon

30 Dylan

31 Peter

SOLUTION (8.5.26)

3	2	6	7	1	9	4	5	8
4	9	1	5	2	8	3	6	7
7	8	5	3	6	4	2	1	9
6	5	8	9	3	7	1	4	2
9	7	3	2	4	1	6	8	5
1	4	2	8	5	6	9	7	3
5	1	9	6	8	2	7	3	4
2	3	4	1	7	5	8	9	6
8	6	7	4	9	3	5	2	1

Tata Power-DDL to hold Lok Adalat for power theft cases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (Tata Power-DDL) will participate in the National Lok Adalat on May 9 to facilitate on-the-spot settlement of electricity theft cases and pending dues related to disconnected power connections in North Delhi.

The Lok Adalat will be organised in collaboration with the Delhi State Legal Services Authority from 10 am to 4 pm at Permanent Lok Adalat-I in Sector 13, Rohini, near Venkateshwar Global School.

According to the power distribution company, consumers interested in resolving pending matters can register for the settlement

process by contacting the company's helpline number 19124. Customers facing issues related to electricity theft bills can also reach out through the company's designated email support, while separate customer care email services have been provided for consumers with outstanding dues linked to disconnect-

ed electricity connections.

The utility advised consumers attending the Lok Adalat to carry a valid photo identity proof along with copies of the disputed electricity bill or disconnected connection bill. Walk-in consumers will also be allowed to directly approach the venue with their Aadhaar card and

relevant documents.

Tata Power-DDL said the initiative aims to provide consumers with an opportunity for amicable resolution of disputes and settlement of outstanding dues through a legal facilitation mechanism.

The company also cautioned that consumers who fail to resolve pending matters could face criminal or civil proceedings under the provisions of the Electricity Act, 2003 and regulations issued by the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC).

To increase public awareness about the initiative, the utility said it is conducting outreach through SMS campaigns and social media platforms.

Assam Rifles foil escalation along Indo-Myanmar border in Kamjong sector of Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Assam Rifles personnel averted a major escalation along the Indo-Myanmar border in Manipur's Kamjong sector after heavy firing and explosions were reported near Z Choro and opposite Namlee in the early hours of May 7, officials said.

According to the Assam Rifles, troops responded swiftly to the volatile situation and moved into the affected area under difficult conditions to safeguard civilians and restore stability.

During the operation, multiple rescue teams were deployed immediately. Security personnel secured around 10 houses affected by the violence and evacuated

civilians from the area.

Fifteen distressed villagers, including women and children, were rescued and provided humanitarian assistance at the Aloyo Assam Rifles camp. Officials also said that a Myanmar woman from Namlee received immediate first aid and medical evacuation support from the troops.

As part of follow-up operations, Assam Rifles conducted rapid area sanitisation exercises to prevent further

escalation of violence and maintain peace in the region.

During search operations, security forces apprehended one armed cadre and recovered an AK-47 rifle along with

a magazine and ammunition. The apprehended individual and seized weapons were later handed over to the local police authorities for further investigation.

verka

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SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022. EPABX NO. 0172-5041812/66

Notice Inviting Tender

Short term e-tender is hereby invited for the purchase of following item:-

Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
For Verka Amritsar Dairy Supply of Indonesian Steam Coal	1000 MT

NOTE:
1. For complete details regarding above tender (NT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in.
2. Contingendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

1018/12/2026-27/11339

General Manager (Purchase)

FROM UNAUTHORIZED TO EMPOWERED

A New Chapter of Urban Transformation Begins in the Capital

DELHI SAYS FROM THE HEART: "THANK YOU, MODI JI"



"This now brings an end to the decades of uncertainty and now gives them a chance to pursue the dreams of their lives in peace, without any threat of eviction or displacement. This would change the **fortune of entire Delhi.** And till the fortune of Delhi changes, the country's fortune will not change."

- Narendra Modi, Prime Minister



For years, millions of families living in unauthorized colonies in Delhi were caught in a strange paradox-they had homes, yet no legal ownership. There was no clear property title, no full access to government services, and no sense of security about the future.

Today, under the visionary leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, Delhi is witnessing a historic transformation where dreams are finally being recognized by law, and homes are being honored with rightful ownership.

This is not just a policy decision; it is an effort to restore identity, dignity, and security to millions who have waited for decades.

Because now, their homes are no longer just places to live-they are legally theirs.

And across the streets of Delhi, a new voice echoes: "Thank you, Modi Ji!"

A New Dawn for 900,000 Families

For over 4.5 million people living in unauthorized colonies, a new era has begun.

These residents have long lived in uncertainty and insecurity. With legal recognition now in place, not only are their property rights strengthened, but they are also gaining social and economic stability.

A dream that remained incomplete for years is finally turning into reality.

This is not merely regularization-it is the restoration of dignity, security, and rights.

— CM Rekha Gupta

PM-UDAY: A Dream Realized

Launched in 2019, the Pradhan Mantri Unauthorized Colonies in Delhi Awas Adhikar Yojana (PM-UDAY) has granted ownership rights to lakhs of families for the first time.

So far, around 40,000 conveyance deeds have been issued. However, due to technical and procedural complexities, progress had been relatively slow.

Now, by removing these bottlenecks, the government has accelerated the scheme with renewed momentum.

"As-is Where-is" - The Guarantee of the Biggest Change

Out of Delhi's 1,731 unauthorized colonies, 1,511 will now be regularized on an "as-is where-is" basis.

What does this mean?

- No requirement for layout plans

NOW DELHI SAYS — THANK YOU, MODI JI

When a family smiles holding the legal papers of their home...
When a young person begins planning their future...
When the first ray of development reaches a colony...

One voice echoes from every heart: "Thank you, Modi Ji!"
"This is not just a scheme-it is trust." A trust that:
• Every citizen will receive their rights
• Development will be inclusive

• Delhi will transform-for the better
"Your city, your responsibility." The government is doing its part-now it's our turn:
• Keep the city clean

• Follow the rules
• Participate in development
Because now, Delhi offers both rights and development-
With Modi Ji: Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas

- Existing homes will be considered legally valid
- All plots approved for residential use
- Relief extended to small shops

This is not just a reform-it is a guarantee of real change in people's lives.

Faster, Transparent, and Simpler Processes

Where files once took months, work will now be completed in days:

- GIS survey report in 7 days
- Deficiency Resolution Memo in 15 days
- Conveyance deed issued within 45 days
- Mandatory maintenance of PM-UDAY register

Additionally:

- ADM appointed as the single nodal officer
- Surveys conducted at the local level
- Online applications through the SWAGAM portal

With digital tracking and application systems, transparency has increased, and citizens no longer need to run from office to office.

This is the new system of a double-engine government-simple, fast, and reliable.

APPLICATIONS OPEN ON THE SWAGAM PORTAL FROM APRIL 24, 2026- YOUR RIGHTS, NOW IN YOUR HANDS

No long queues...
No middlemen...
Just one click-and your home becomes legally yours.

Not Just Homes, It's a Vikas Ki Guarantee

With regularization, these colonies will now see structured development by government agencies.

Earlier, unclear legal status limited development. Now, infrastructure investment will increase.

What has changed?

- MCD will issue Regularisation Certificates
- Revenue Department will provide Conveyance Deeds and Authorization Slips
- Infrastructure development will be ensured

Now, colonies will have:

- Better roads
- Safer streets
- Modern amenities

A New Vision for Delhi: TOD Policy

While rights are being granted, the future is also being strengthened.

Enter the Transit Oriented Development (TOD) Policy.

This policy aims to integrate transport and housing by promoting high-density, planned development around metro and transit corridors.

It enables people to live closer to transit, improving ease of living and encouraging walkability.

What will change?

- Affordable housing options
- Better connectivity
- Smart and planned urban growth

A New Era of Affordable Housing

Under the new policy:

- Development within 500 meters on both sides of Metro/RTS corridors
 - Around 207 sq. km area opened for development
 - Smaller plots (minimum 2000 sq. m) now eligible
 - Maximum FAR increased up to 500
 - 65% FAR mandatory for residential use
 - Promotion of affordable housing units (< 99 sq. m)
 - Remaining FAR allowed for commercial and flexible use
- Regularization of unauthorized colonies and the TOD policy together will redefine housing, urban development, and ease of living in Delhi.
- This is not just about regularization-it is a step toward an inclusive, planned, and modern urban model that ensures better quality of life and infrastructure.

Now Every Family's Dream of "Owning a Home" Will Come True

A Major Step Toward Inclusive Development

Earlier, several areas were excluded from the TOD policy. Now, an additional 80 sq. km has been included.

This means:

- Unauthorized colonies enter the mainstream of development
 - Land pooling areas are now included
- Now, Delhi's landscape will change-and so will its mindset.
- This is no longer just about homes-it's about the future of the entire city.
- This initiative will:
- Transform unplanned growth into

- organized development
- Empower citizens
- Elevate Delhi to a world-class city

Delhi's New Urban Vision: A Step Toward Transformation

Regularization of unauthorized colonies and the TOD policy are not just about legal recognition-they lay the foundation of a modern urban model where every citizen has access to better infrastructure, connectivity, and quality of life.

From Reality to Resolution

Over the past two decades, Delhi's population has nearly doubled. Rapid urban expansion led to unplanned development in many areas-resulting in thousands of unauthorized colonies, hundreds of slums, and numerous villages with inadequate infrastructure.

For years, this reality was ignored. Now, the policy focus has shifted-from avoidance to acceptance, and from problem to practical solution.

The Delhi of Tomorrow: Planned, Inclusive, Capable

With support from the central government, this initiative marks a strong beginning toward transforming Delhi into a systematic and planned city.

Its impact will go beyond infrastructure-it will redefine lifestyle, connectivity, and the overall urban experience.

This is not just development-it is the beginning of a new identity for Delhi.

DIP/Shabdarth/Advertorial/019/26-27



THIS IS MORE THAN A POLICY-IT IS A PROMISE FULFILLED

Spin choke and Allen's blitz power KKR past DC



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Kolkata Knight Riders' spinners strangled Delhi Capitals with a ruthless choke before Finn Allen unleashed a brutal six-hitting exhibition to power the visitors to a comfortable eight-wicket win and reignite their IPL playoff hopes here on Friday.

The spin trio of Anukul Roy (2/31), Sunil Narine (1/17) and Varun Chakravarthy (0/28), stifled Delhi's batting line-up, restricting them to a modest 142 for 8 despite a sparkling 29-ball 50 from Pathum Nissanka.

Impact substitute Allen

then produced a fearless knock at the top. The Kiwi hit an astonishing 10 sixes and five fours in his unbeaten 47-ball 100 as KKR chased down the target on 14.2 overs.

The win, KKR's fourth on trot, catapulted them to seventh place while the loss, DC's seventh in 11 games this season, has all but killed their chances of making the playoffs.

Defending a below-par total, Delhi desperately searched for early breakthroughs and briefly found hope through moments of fortune.

Ajinkya Rahane was run out after the ball brushed

Mitchell Starc's fingertips onto the stumps at the non-striker's end, while Angkrish Raghuvanshi was undone when the ball flicked his glove and rolled back onto the stumps.

But Allen's fearless stroke-play ensured KKR never lost sight of the chase as he dismantled the DC attack with clean hitting and aggressive intent. Earlier, if it wasn't for Ashutosh Sharma's 39 off 28 balls which was laced with three boundaries and as many sixes, DC would have struggled to even cross the 100-run mark.

KKR's pacers complemented the spinners superbly,

with Kartik Tyagi (2/25), Vaibhav Arora (1/29) and Cameron Green (1/12) striking at key moments to ensure Delhi never found sustained rhythm.

Asked to bat, Nissanka (50) and KL Rahul (23) provided Delhi a fluent start, with the Sri Lankan taking the aggressive route early, striking the innings' first boundary and six.

KKR, however, showed complete faith in their spin resources from the outset, handing the ball to Roy and Narine inside the powerplay.

Though the Delhi openers negotiated the challenge

well initially, the pressure steadily mounted as the spinners dried up the boundaries post the powerplay.

Once Tyagi and Green removed Rahul and Nitish Rana (8) in quick succession, KKR unleashed their spin stranglehold in full force.

Chakravarthy turned the screws with a suffocating three-run over spell, forcing the batters into riskier options.

Narine then struck immediately after returning to the attack, dismissing Sameer Rizvi, who misused a sweep straight to deep midwicket.

Nissanka briefly resisted, bringing up his fifty with a

crisp boundary through extra cover, but Roy outfoxed him off the very next delivery as the batter was stumped trying to break free.

Roy then compounded Delhi's misery by bamboozling Tristan Stubbs in the same over, triggering another collapse as DC lost four wickets in the middle overs while KKR's spinners completely strangled the innings.

Ashutosh finally broke the 38-ball boundary drought with a six. He followed it up with back-to-back boundaries to collect 16 runs off the 17th over before adding another six and a four.

The win means a lot to us, says LSG skipper Pant

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Captain Rishabh Pant said Lucknow Super Giants' win over defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru meant a lot to the struggling side as they finally snapped a six-match losing streak in the ongoing IPL here on Thursday.

LSG ended their barren run with a nine-run DLS victory in a rain-interrupted 19-overs-a-side contest, which also marked their first home win in five matches this season.

"It was a good game for us for sure. For the whole team it means a lot. We have been trying lot of things. Coming to the same page means a lot for us. It's been a tough season but some times you have to go through the grind. "Definitely we were trying to put together a perfect game where batting and bowling comes together," Pant said.

Talking about picking Digvesh Rathi for the final over while defending 20 runs, Pant said: "It was a tough call. We were under pressure. Rathi was the right matchup for (Romario) Shepherd."

He also had words of appreciation for centurion Mitchell Marsh.

"Unbelievable (Marsh



innings). We know that as a team we've been grinding hard. Our strength this season has been bowling, the way all the bowlers have put their heart out. There has been some good things as a bowling unit, and looking forward to that."

RCB captain Rajat Patidar said they were well on course of the target but fell two-three hits behind.

"We were pretty sure how to go about the target. Boys played well and the way we stretched this game, just one or two shots behind. It was really good batting track. Was coming nicely on the bat. Difficult to analyse just after the game, need some time to analyse it."

Dhoni got angry when I celebrated too much after getting his wicket: Ashwin recalls



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Retired India spin great Ravichandran Ashwin on Friday revealed that his excessive celebration after dismissing Mahendra Singh Dhoni in Challenger Trophy early in his career had actually annoyed the iconic former captain.

Speaking on JioStar's 'The Ravichandran Ashwin Experience', the off-spinner recalled that he thought his dismissal of Dhoni could give him a chance to play for Chennai Super Kings in IPL.

"Mutthiah Muralitharan was in the team, a legend, bowling his full quota, so I wasn't getting chances (to play for CSK). I didn't play in 2008, but in 2009, I got my first game in Cape Town, against Mumbai Indians, against Sachin Tendulkar. Between 2009 and 2010, I still didn't get many opportunities," said Ashwin who retired from all forms of international cricket in December 2024.

In the Challenger Trophy, I got a chance to bowl to Dhoni. Dhoni got out twice against our team. Once, he hit a shot towards deep cover and I took a diving catch. I celebrated it so much that he actually got annoyed.

BCCI warns franchises of honey trap

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

The BCCI on Thursday issued an eight-page directive for the 10 IPL franchises flagging off concerns about some serious breaches of protocols while setting Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) which will need to be strictly adhered to in near future.

"The advisory has been issued in light of certain incidents observed during ongoing season and is intended to reinforce the standards of professionalism, discipline, security awareness and protocol compliance expected from all stakeholders associated with IPL," BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia wrote to CEOs of 10 franchises, a copy of which is in possession of PTI.

The eight-page documents sets the record straight while pointing out about the breaches that has been reported by the Anti Corruption and Security Unit (ACSU) of BCCI.

In the 'Preamble', Saikia writes: "It has come to the attention of the BCCI that certain incidents of misconduct and protocol violation have occurred involving players and support staff and team officials during the course of the current IPL season. These incidents if left unaddressed, carry the potential to cause significant reputational harm to the tournament,



the Franchise concerned and the BCCI as the Governing Body. They may further expose individuals and franchises to legal liability and security risks of serious nature."

One of the major concerns has been visits from "unauthorized persons" in players' hotel rooms.

The document states: "It has been observed that certain players and support staff members have permitted unauthorised persons to access their hotel rooms without the knowledge or approval of the concerned IPL franchise Team Manager. (PTI)

Gujarat Titans look to win against RR



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

An upbeat Gujarat Titans will be determined to continue their winning streak and leapfrog a wobbly Rajasthan Royals in their mid-table Indian Premier League clash here on Saturday.

Only the net run rate separates the 2022 edition winners Gujarat Titans (-0.147) from the fourth-placed 2008 champion Rajasthan Royals (0.510) in the points table as the two teams have fared alike so far. Both GT and RR have six wins and four defeats in 10 matches each.

But the Shubman Gill-led side will fancy their chances against the wobbly Royals, who have suffered three defeats in their last five matches. The Titans have racked up three wins on the trot and looking to break into the top four.

Royals captain Riyan Parag struck 90 in RR's first-innings score of 225 for six but it was not enough against Delhi Capitals who overhauled it with seven wickets and five balls to spare. It was the second such instance in a row when a first-innings total in excess of 220 could not be defended by the Royals.

While Rajasthan Royals are indeed top-heavy with Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (404 runs), Yashasvi Jaiswal (312) and even Dhruv Jurel (290) doing the heavy lifting, they will need their skipper to fire big in the lower order, which has only Donovan Ferreira (229) hitting at 150 or above.



KSCA requested for additional 10,057 complimentary IPL tickets: BCCI source

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

The Karnataka State Cricket Association's (KSCA) request for additional 10,057 complimentary tickets led to the shifting of IPL final and playoff matches from the M Chinnaswamy Stadium here, a BCCI source has said.

Bengaluru was to host the final going by convention as Royal Challengers Bengaluru



are the defending champions. But IPL chairman Arun Dhimal told

PTI that it became "untenable" to have the finale here due to high demand for complimentary tickets at the relatively low-capacity venue,

which can only accommodate 35,000 fans. This season's playoff fixtures will be held in Dharamsala (May 26) and New Chandigarh (May 27 and 29) while the title clash (May 31) will be staged at the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad.

"The KSCA is entitled to complimentary tickets amounting to 15 per cent of the stadium capacity. However, KSCA requested for an additional 10,057 tickets," the source revealed to PTI.

In that, the association needed around

900 passes to meet the demands of the state legislature members alone. "KSCA agreed to provide three complimentary passes each to MLAs/MLCs (approximately 900 passes in total).

"Further, the Expert Committee and the additional commitments with the Government of Karnataka would have required an additional 750 complimentary tickets in addition to a limited number of hospitality complimentary passes beyond the standard 15 per cent."

I felt good after Virat Kohli's wicket, says Prince Yadav



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Lucknow Super Giants pacer Prince Yadav dismissed Royal Challengers Bengaluru batting stalwart Virat Kohli with a peach of a delivery during their IPL match here but the youngster does not want to play it up, saying that he was

just happy that his team won.

In the second over of RCB's run chase of 210, Prince Yadav produced a sensational delivery to bamboozle Kohli. The 140-kmph ball nipped back to crash into Kohli's off stump. It marked Kohli's first IPL duck since a first-ball dismissal against Rajasthan Royals in April 2023.

Suryansh Shedge looking to make most of correct shot selection

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Punjab Kings all-rounder Suryansh Shedge says he has spent considerable time in the nets working on his mindset and shot selection under former India player and selector Jatin Paranjape.

The 23-year-old Shedge had to wait for his opportunity in the Indian Premier League but made a strong dent with a valiant 57 for Punjab Kings against Gujarat Titans. He followed it up with a brisk 25 off 17 balls against Sunrisers Hyderabad.

Shedge said he has worked on his mindset to think clearly in pressure situations under Paranjape at



the Vasu Paranjape Cricket Centre here.

"The last one and a half years have been extremely important for me. Jatin sir helped me work not just on my batting, but also on my mindset and confidence. He always pushed me to back my natural game and think

clearly under pressure," Shedge told PTI on Friday.

Paranjape said it is important for cricketers to have the right decision-making skills. "A lot of young cricketers today have talent, but the difference often comes down to mindset and decision-making," he said.

Don't want money, just want to know our country is watching: Satwik

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Ace doubles badminton player Satwiksairaj Rankireddy on Friday said his recent comments on the muted public reception after the Indian team won Thomas Cup bronze medal were not intended to seek "money or grand parades" but to urge the people "to celebrate every win, big or small" in all sports.

The world Number 4 pair of Satwik and Chirag Shetty, the Asian Games champions, were part of the Indian team that recently claimed a bronze medal in the Thomas Cup in Denmark but the former had



expressed his emotions on social media on the lack of recognition for their effort.

After returning home from Denmark, Satwik wrote, "Back home now. As usual, no one knows what

happened over the past two weeks, and it seems like no one really cares."

On Friday, 25-year-old Satwik put out another social media post to elaborate his thoughts.